NELSON INNO

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WESPARK

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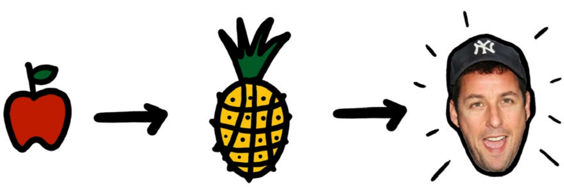
For those who fall a thousand times and rise each time, ready to fly again.

CONTENTS

1. Opening Chaos

Apple, Pineapple, Adam Sandler.



At first glance, these words seem unrelated. However, there is a thread connecting these ideas. I once asked Artificial Intelligence what these words might have in common. Interestingly, it suggested they are loosely connected by “themes of contrast or the unexpected”—which is both near and far from the truth.

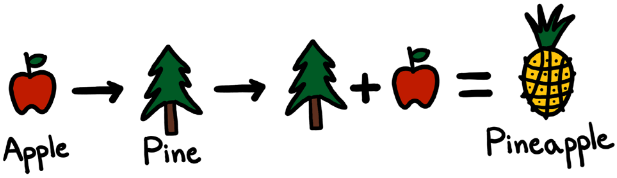
Innovation thrives in chaos—much like our own thoughts that leap between ideas unpredictably. The process doesn’t follow a straight line, but the good news is that we’ll explore how to build a foundation that navigates and conquers chaos and makes the best out of it.

“Apple, Pineapple, Adam Sandler” share something in common but differ from what you might think. They tell a story—a story of how our minds think. In this case, it's a personal example, and it might not make sense to you at first, but bear with me. I will explain.

We constantly jump from one thought to another, combining ideas and concepts in seemingly random ways. Yet, there’s a logic behind it, even if parts of that process remain hidden in the background. Some thoughts are more present and are highlighted in the words we say or remember, while others quietly stay behind the scenes.

What we often miss is context—and that missing context usually holds the majority of the story. So, let me provide the hidden context for you: When I thought about this example, I started with the word “apple,” and my mind made logical connections—nature, fruits, trees. Some fruits grow on trees, and there are many types of trees: oak, willow, palm, and pine. Suddenly, I’ve jumped from “apple” to the new word “pine.” I reordered these thoughts, putting the words “pine” first and “apple” second. The result? Pineapple!

This is a simulation of the thinking process. It uses the association of ideas and a process called synthesis, one of the most powerful tools for generating new ideas through “innovation by combination.”



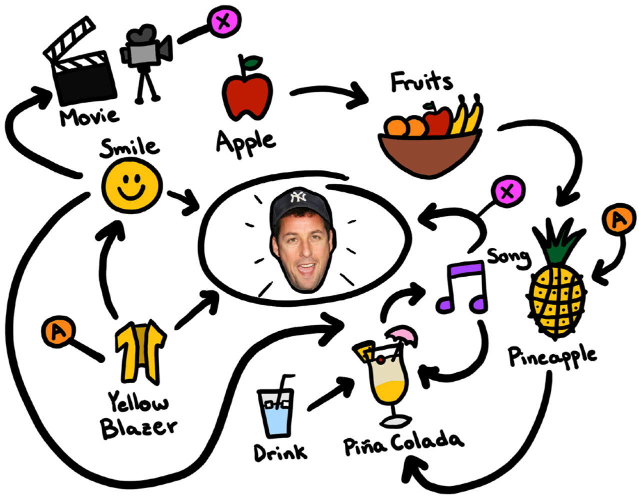
This process can happen automatically, and some creatives can activate it consciously by following innovation methods, a topic we will cover as we move forward. For now, you should consider that there’s usually some connection between thoughts. The mind wanders, creating links between emotions, senses, experiences, memories, and more. How often have you caught yourself in a conversation where you asked yourself: "Wait, how did we get to this topic?" But if you go into full-detective mode, you might trace the line of thought back to its origins.

Now, let’s continue with the context. I'm sorry to keep you waiting, but… Where did Adam Sandler come from!?

When I first came up with this example, I was confused, too—this happened in 2019 while I was in the middle of a book conference. In a quick moment of mindfulness, I caught myself and asked, "Why am I thinking about Adam Sandler right now?" What kind of magic or marketing trick is at play here? To find out, I used one of my favorite skills: I started visualizing a temporary mind map and connecting the dots.

When I worked backward from Adam Sandler, I realized that I had arrived at this conclusion by connecting the apple with a smiling woman who had passed by wearing a striking yellow blazer. Combining these two concepts —the apple and the color yellow— triggered my mind to create "pineapple." From there, my mind combined the drink I got offered with the pineapple, and the thought “piña colada” appeared. Simultaneously, the woman’s smile brought me back to a happy moment from a few days earlier when I did a video shoot for one of my companies. The thought of movies and the sudden familiar tune, "If you like piña coladas and getting caught in the rain," came to my mind. While listening to the song in my head, I recalled the last movie I had seen with this song, and I arrived at "Grown Ups" with Adam Sandler.

And that’s how my mind went from "apple" to "Adam Sandler" in just about three seconds.



Even though I tried to simplify the last few paragraphs, they may still seem confusing—and that’s because they are. All of this is just a mysterious way of how the mind works. It’s holistic, unstructured, and visual. Is this what people call a "Creative Mind"? Or is my brain just malfunctioning? We might never know.

But one question arose: Can this automatic creativity process be controlled, steered, and harnessed to solve a specific problem at will? I don’t have a definitive answer yet, but it’s an idea worth exploring.

As a kid, I struggled to communicate my ideas. More often than not, I was misunderstood or ignored. This chaotic process felt more like a curse than a blessing. Imagine being a child and believing that most of what you say is wrong. Thankfully, my teachers and parents noticed the problem and enrolled me in a couple of boot camps that taught me how to structure and express my thoughts more effectively.

Still, it wasn't until my mid-20s that I had my "Aha!" moment. I discovered that putting my ideas on paper—whether through a sketch or a prototype—could change everything. With visuals, I could communicate clearly, make my ideas compelling, and win almost anyone to my side. This realization transformed my career and life. Visualization is a skill, and the good news is that it's one you can learn, too.

That's why you'll find several sketches throughout the next chapters. For some ideas, words alone just don't cut it. And let's be honest—if you're reading a book about innovation, you probably didn't expect a strict, linear process. The truth is uncertainty and innovation often go hand in hand. Chaos is a natural part of the journey.

While frameworks can guide us, creativity doesn't adhere to rigid rules. Instead, it flows unpredictably, influenced by countless factors outside our control. The best we can do is build a strong foundation—one that helps us embrace the chaos and improve our odds of success.

Some of the most extraordinary situations happen for reasons we can't fully understand. An infinite number of variables influence whether innovation happens or not, and they are constantly changing and creating fragile opportunities for radical transformation to become possible. With this in mind, the rest of this book will be about increasing your chances of becoming an innovator. It's not guaranteed, but you might stand a chance if you prepare and act accordingly.

My father, who loves using football (soccer) metaphors to explain business, often says, "The best goalkeeper isn't the one with the best skills, but the one with sensational skills and incredible luck." So, does this mean you must work hard and be lucky to become an innovator? I will get back to you and answer this question once we covered a few fundamentals.

Indeed, we can't control everything, especially our luck. However, we can train ourselves to react when opportunities arise. If innovation thrives in chaos and uncertainty, we must train ourselves to navigate within that chaos.

In the following chapters, we'll dive deeper into the dynamics of innovation, examining real-life examples and uncovering the actionable steps that can help you prepare for when innovation knocks. From managing uncertainty to embracing chaos, we'll explore how to turn unpredictability into opportunity and sharpen the skills needed to compete in this ever-changing world. While innovation comes with no guarantees, together, we'll explore how to improve our chances by embracing the chaos that fuels it.

2. UNMEASURABLE ACCELERATION

Most people are obsessed with speed—how fast they can go, who the fastest human is, or which car can reach the highest speed. But acceleration, not speed, is what's truly exciting—at least at the scales we experience here on Earth.

What's the difference? Speed is the rate at which an object changes position. Add direction, like "moving north," and it becomes velocity. When velocity increases, acceleration occurs. So, acceleration is simply the rate at which velocity changes.

In innovation, acceleration is the process that transforms industries rapidly—sometimes faster than we can measure or predict. Before we explore how acceleration and innovation relate, let's discover what makes acceleration so intriguing.

Practically speaking, we feel acceleration more than speed. Have you ever been driving on the highway and suddenly realized you're going much faster than expected? Why didn't you feel it? Or how can you comfortably sip tea on a high-speed train in Europe or Japan?

We simply tend to experience acceleration more directly than speed! Every morning, we battle gravity, which accelerates us toward Earth's center, luckily countered by the solid ground beneath us. We've adapted to this gravitational pull, yet it still makes us feel our weight.

Remember the last time you floored the accelerator in your car? That intense sensation of being pressed into your seat—that's horizontal acceleration! It feels exciting! And once you are going very fast, the thrill is not the speed itself but the risk of decelerating too quickly.

Still not convinced? Right now, as you read this, you're rotating on Earth's surface at 1,670 km/h (1,040 mph)—and you don't feel it. The entire Milky Way, including us, is moving through space at 2.1 million km/h (1.3 million mph). Do you feel that?

In comparison, if we were to accelerate Earth's rotational speed by only 0.1 m/s^2 (10cm, or 3.9in per second) for one hour, the results would be nauseating and catastrophic! Days would halve in length, and we'd see earthquakes, tsunamis, wild weather, and volcanic eruptions as the new norm. One day of constant acceleration like this would send us flying off the planet and tear Earth apart.

Imagine that humans can accelerate approximately 2 to 4 m/s^2 for 1 to 2 seconds, while sports cars can hit 7 m/s^2 but only for 2 to 3 seconds. These numbers seem comparably high to our apocalyptic scenario, but then again, they involve small objects and short timeframes. What's unbelievable is how a tiny sustained increment of our planet's speed can literally throw us out of orbit.

We learn that sustained acceleration, even over a single hour, can cause massive changes, chaos, and uncertainty, but why are we talking about acceleration, and how is it related to innovation?

Just like acceleration can dramatically alter the physical world, innovation is the acceleration of ideas, breakthroughs, and technologies that shift entire industries. As our population grows, more people actively contribute to science, technology, and overall progress. As we continue to discover new technologies more frequently, we come across impactful discoveries that unlock and speed up the development of even more technologies.

Artificial intelligence is the trending example, enabling other technologies to be developed faster in virtually all industries. In Gartner's Hype Cycle for Artificial Intelligence, 29 sub-technologies are being built as of this writing. Each of these opens new opportunities for discoveries to be made.

In the book *The Price of Tomorrow*, Jeff Booth argues that technologies are inherently deflationary, adding more value at a cheaper price over time and reaching more people. Just consider how big and expensive old telephones, video cameras, televisions, and other consumer electronics were in the last century. Now compare them to today's smartphones that not only allow us to take our phones with us but also include photo and video cameras, online television, access to the internet, email, AI assistants, and over 2 million apps that add all sorts of comfort and functionalities. At the same time, these services went from being barely affordable to being widely accessible for a more significant part of society.

Another example is the cost of sequencing a human genome, which dropped from $100 million to below $1,000 in 20 years, according to *NHGRI* data. At the same time, accessibility opens up immensely, and the number of professionals working in the industry starts to grow exponentially. In other words, working with human DNA has become significantly more accessible and cheaper over time. All in all, these technologies not only disrupt existing industries but also unlock further technological advancements, creating a compounding effect and accelerating innovation.

Do you feel everything is changing faster today than in the past decades? Does this change excite you or make you anxious? Although things have been changing drastically for a long time, it might just be that we are feeling the compounding acceleration of technologies and innovation.

In terms of innovation, is it possible to calculate acceleration? And how do we know whether we are changing too slowly or too fast? To measure innovation, we can check the number of patent filings, scientific publications, WIPO's global innovation index, reports about R&D expenditures, and adoption rates of multiple technologies. However, what about all the undocumented research, corporate secrets, social innovations, non-technical advances, and, in general, everything that is happening now that is unaccounted for? If you think about all the unstructured data in the world, it is nearly impossible to define a single, universal unit of measurement that catches it all.

When we make estimations, we often see a picture of the past, a speed value of what was. We're accelerating so quickly that any data analyzed today might be obsolete by the time it's published. Due to the increasing, already immense amount of knowledge available, there will likely always be more we don't know than we do. As someone who has been trying to catch an overview of all major updates and changes in the world's social and technological trends, I can tell you that this process can be relatively stress- and anxiety-inducing. Sometimes, it's just better to assume that change is taking place faster than we can comprehend and measure it—allowing you more mental clarity and time to dedicate to the topics and trends more relevant to you.

One reason why accelerated innovation can induce anxiety is that sometimes, changes happen so fast that the metrics we use to measure innovation can break. A famous example is OpenAI's ChatGPT models: the go-to metric to compare how fast these versions of Artificial Intelligence chats were developing was the number of parameters—essentially the data points used to train the model. This parameter number grew from millions to billions to trillions in just half a decade.

model	year	parameters
GPT 1	2018	117m
GPT 2	2019	1.5b
GPT 3	2020	175b
GPT 4	2023	>1t
GPT 4o	2024	?
GPT 1o	2024	?

But here's the catch: in 2023, tracking parameters became less relevant. The focus shifted to how efficiently the AI can perform real-world tasks, handle complex prompts, and process images and documents, making this technology much more powerful than a simple metric can capture. In short, GPT’s technological advances rendered parameters as a measuring unit useless.

Another well-known example, especially among GPU fans, is from 2018 when *NVIDIA* CEO Jensen Huang unveiled the Turing-powered GeForce RTX 20-series graphics card. Huang explained how much faster the new technology was compared to the fastest GPU on the market at the time, adding: “This has simply never happened before, doing computer graphics. Essentially a supercomputer replaced by one GPU within one generation. [...] So, the question is, what is happening under the hood? This is a new computing model, so there’s a new way to think about performance. It’s a new computing model, so there needs to be new metrics.” Like many groundbreaking innovations, this wasn’t just about making things faster—it was about rethinking the way we approach and measure performance and progress.

Updating the way we measure progress is one of the signs that we are progressing and innovating fast. Roughly between 40,000 and 14,000 years ago, we were visualizing stories inside caves by carving walls and documenting our knowledge. Then, between 3400 and 3100 BCE, we invented a transportable writing system, the Kish tablet. Fast forward to our era, where with minimal skills, we can document anything in text, images, videos, code, 3D models, and prints. Today, you can create basic versions of almost any digital media with a single AI prompt. How many times did we rethink the way we measure innovation and progress? Just think about how ridiculous it would be to try to measure today's technology based on the Kish tablet's "quality of clay."

More often than not, innovations happen without us being aware of their development. We become aware of their existence only when they go public, and we finally interact with them. In the past 30 years, there have been two major changes to the *HTTP* protocol we use daily online. Yet, innovation continues quietly under our noses, often unnoticed until it becomes critical. A great example of quiet innovation is the new *Hypertext Spatial Transaction Protocol* (HSTP), recently approved by the *Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers* (IEEE), the world's leading authority on advancing technology. Built for the next era of the internet—one that's spatial and immersive—*HSTP* will help unlock 3D and augmented reality experiences. It's the kind of breakthrough most people don't notice at first, but it could soon reshape how we all navigate the digital world, making the internet far more dynamic and immersive than we know today. When we first interact with it, we will most likely experience that everything is changing faster, even though this large engineering undertaking has already been developed.

Just like some technological innovations will surprise us, eventually, we might transmit ideas through our minds to digital mental interfaces, and possibly, we will see our ideas materialize in a few minutes in front of our eyes with something like a “home-atom-fabricator” that creates physical objects out of thin air. Transhumanism, or the ability to use technology to enhance human physical, cognitive, and emotional capacities, could just become as cheap and accessible as makeup products today. Our AI agents will likely take more physical forms and potentially, for the first time, be aware of what is going on in the real world in real-time. Or… who knows!?

A crude fact about innovation is that it doesn’t care about your or my opinion. In the past years, I’ve been a speaker at several innovation and tech conferences; there, I experienced that the claims of experts and futurists are often based on a single wild assertion by a single charismatic speaker with some wild and fascinating claims. Since we tend to favor sensational stories over more rational explanations, we can end up repeating them. Word of mouth spreads these wild claims because it is safer and easier to repeat what others say than to form our own opinions, eventually leading to a trending narrative created by so-called “experts.” I remember that in 2019, Key Opinion Leaders (KOLs) were talking left and right at conferences about what would happen in 2030 based on the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals. Yet all those claims about the future fell silent as the COVID-19 pandemic caught everyone off guard. Today, a single update can change the AI landscape overnight and have a consequential breakthrough in all industries. The impact could be even higher, considering that it’s a technology with the power to create or destroy.

It's not uncommon to see experts who make completely wrong claims; for example, Thomas Edison said in 1889: “Fooling around with alternating current (AC) is just a waste of time. Nobody will use it, ever.” Even though he was an expert in electric current generation and the distribution of direct current (DC), he failed to see how alternating current allowed electricity transmission over long distances with a cheaper, more scalable system. In our fast-changing times, making accurate predictions that hold the test of time becomes rarer.

Ego, bias, ignorance, and information overload are just some of the disruptors that can cloud our thinking. At the beginning of my entrepreneurial journey, I founded the innovation agency *WeSpark*—a topic I’ll dive deeper into in the following chapters. As a first-time founder, my inexperience in running a business led to several mistakes. For a time, I believed that an innovation agency should always stay on top of every major advancement across multiple industries. I spent countless hours subscribing to newsletters, exploring platforms, and consuming content about innovation, Megatrends, and technology.

These activities pulled me away from my core responsibility: understanding potential customers' challenges. Instead of addressing real, present-day problems, I found myself lost in endless possibilities of what the future might hold. This approach not only missed the mark with WeSpark’s customers but also left me feeling overwhelmed and misaligned.

The first six months were brutal—I didn’t secure a single customer, my savings were nearly depleted, and failure seemed inevitable. It wasn’t until I learned to let go of chasing every innovation trend that I shifted my focus to meaningful conversations with potential clients. That’s when I learned my first entrepreneurial lesson: companies don’t want every flashy, futuristic tool or tech thrown at them. They want someone to listen, diagnose their problems, and address them in ways that set them up for growth and self-sustaining innovation. Amid complexity, customers value simplicity and clear direction.

In the seventh month, we signed our first client. Within weeks, five more followed, and WeSpark's story began to change for the better. From that point forward, we refined our focus, gaining expertise in innovation management and development. Today, we specialize in three verticals: energy and connectivity, freedom tech, and spatial internet.

This sharper focus has made navigating change far easier. When we notice a recurring topic that aligns with our goals and customers' needs, we start with a few hours of research. If the trend shows promise, we allocate more resources to explore and test it. By staying intentional and customer-focused, *WeSpark* has continued to grow and adapt, turning challenges into opportunities.

Every new day is more important for human history than the one before, as newer technologies allow us to generate more impact with fewer resources. Therefore, considering all the accelerated innovation, there's no better time to innovate than today.

In Chapter 1, we explored the idea that innovation is most likely to happen during times of turbulence or crisis. With this in mind, perhaps it's time to embrace the fact that we will never fully understand everything happening in the world. Accepting this uncertainty allows us to be intentionally selective, focusing on a specific area, industry, or expertise where we know change is both necessary and possible.

The years ahead promise even more acceleration and uncertainty. In the midst of this chaos, innovators will choose the problems they care about most and step forward with their brilliant ideas. And when the time comes, so will you.

3. THE MOMENT OF TRUTH

Innovation, like life, is full of uneven opportunities, but those who embrace this truth can turn it to their advantage. Many times, life will deal you the worst hand: fewer opportunities, more demanding challenges, or terrible outcomes, and you will perceive the world as unfair. Where you're born, your background, and even random events shape your life in ways that aren't always fair and can't be controlled. In my experience, you have two choices: you can complain about it, or you can act accordingly.

If you choose to complain about the unfairness in life and dwell on it, you'll find yourself stuck in the cycle of relieving pain and frustration. Even if the suffering is small, we learned that tiny repeating conditions compound over time. On the other hand, if you accept that the world is unfair as truth and act on it, you're already on the path toward recognizing the initial step in any innovation journey: your moment of truth.

There will be no shortcuts, fancy technology, or expert hacks when seeking your moment of truth. Innovation doesn’t work like that, as it has a sense of randomness. What matters is being mentally and emotionally prepared for when the moment arrives. While there is no straightforward way to prepare for them, what has worked for me so far is to build a solid foundation: I realized that skills and knowledge are essential but can be acquired or paid for. On the other hand, wisdom and mindset come from living through life’s hardest lessons; more than being something you learn, these are ways of living you adopt. When the moments of truth come, your wisdom and mindset will guide you through the most challenging decisions and the darkest times. Think of your foundation as a ground floor: Once you understand that you are at the mountain’s base, the only way is up.

One benefit of accepting that the world is unjust is that starting from this negative state can’t be unseen. When you face unfairness, you shouldn’t ignore it; you should take responsibility and action. The opportunities for improving what’s unfair in the world are practically unlimited. Even if you upgrade the world with multiple projects, there will still be enough room for improvement.

In the past thousands of years, curiosity, dreams, accidents, and an obsessive need to solve “unsolvable” challenges were some of the most common triggers that changed the lives of earlier inventors, innovators, and the course of history. These triggers became the moments of truth we seek to understand. The second they arrive, your decision will split your story into two dimensions with significantly different outcomes, one where you decide to pursue your endeavor and another where you ignore it, and everything stays as is.

While nobody can predict the future with certainty, I expect the coming years to bring more frequent moments of truth. I base this expectation on three trends I’ve been observing: the first, discussed in Chapter 2, is the rapid technological acceleration we are experiencing. The second is the new social dynamics the internet has introduced; social media allows for any news, products, services, perspectives, and other potentially impactful topics to be spread through digital word of mouth to an increasing number of people in a decreasing amount of time. In short, faster mass communication accelerates adoption, and more rapid adoption accelerates change. The third is a fragile and seemingly unsustainable monetary system that will be covered in more detail in Chapter 5. All three factors are compounding and will likely create more opportunities for innovation.

When these moments arrive, the window of opportunity can be short—sometimes just a few seconds—and other times, they can last weeks or months. Usually, larger challenges come with longer windows of opportunity, but the decision to take action often happens in a few seconds. Whether it's a big or small problem, you must act on time or risk missing them altogether. The unstable nature of these moments makes them even harder to handle, so the more time you have available to work on a solution, the better. Whether these moments come during a calm moment or intense stress, they require you to make a decision in the face of uncertainty.

Often, these decisions are uncomfortable because the risks you face in the short term can seem overwhelming compared to the potential long-term rewards, but this discomfort is part of the process. Recognizing these moments and being prepared to act is what will set you apart.

Consider the story of *Zipline*, a drone delivery company that seized a critical moment of truth and turned it into a life-saving innovation. The Ministry of Health in Rwanda faced dire challenges: medical product shortages and supply chain inefficiencies. In a country known as the "land of a thousand hills," poor infrastructure made it nearly impossible to deliver vital medical supplies efficiently and on time.

Recognizing the urgency of this problem, the Rwandan government and the founders of *Zipline* didn't just acknowledge the issue—they took bold, decisive action. The *Zipline* team leveraged their expertise in robotics and aviation to develop autonomous drones capable of swiftly transporting blood, vaccines, anti-venom, and essential medicines to clinics and hospitals that were previously unreachable.

In an interview with Keller Rinaudo, Zipline's CEO and Co-Founder, and Rwanda's President, Paul Kagame, Rinaudo reflected on those early days. "Maybe today it looks obvious," Rinaudo said, "but I don't think it looked obvious in 2016 when you first bet on us. [...] All of the experts we spoke to told us that this idea wasn't going to work. You were really the first person who bet on *Zipline* as a team and on this idea. Why did you do that?" President Kagame's response was simple yet profound: Rwanda had faced discouraging situations in the past, but they knew they just "needed to try."

Where would *Zipline* be today if they hadn't partnered with Rwanda? It's impossible to say. However, what we know is that Keller Rinaudo and President Kagame shared a vision and commitment to act on it. Together, they built and piloted Zipline's operation, which has since grown exponentially, completing millions of deliveries and saving countless lives.

Like many entrepreneurial journeys, this story underscores two critical steps during pivotal moments of truth: recognizing the opportunity and taking bold, sustained action.

First, you will want to identify your moment of truth, as sometimes, they can be pretty subtle, and other times, crystal clear. Properly identifying opportunities can require a mix of wisdom and knowledge, so you must live, learn, and experience a diverse life to recognize more opportunities. There's no way around this: you'll have to accumulate knowledge through travel and work in different fields, from the pain points of traditional established industries to the promises and dreams of startups.

Lack of knowledge can make you miss opportunities. A recent example is an elderly Romanian woman who used one big stone as a doorstep for decades. One day, one of her relatives inherited her house and had a closer look at the brownish rock that held the door. To his surprise, the rock was, in fact, a 3.5kg (7.7 pounds) amber nugget worth over a million euros; it was eventually sold to the Romanian state and was classified as a national treasure. While this is not an example of innovation, we should consider that the untrained eye is blind to opportunity. If you don't know what to look for, you'll never find anything.

Circling back to the moments of truth, the second suggestion is to have the skills and motivation to take action for as long as required. It's common to project yourself and see the outcome and the positive impact on your life and others at the end of the journey. It's much like a dream, but it's short-lived. For an instant, you feel pumped; you know this is your calling and have spotted an amazing opportunity, but just before it begins, you ask yourself how to start. Suddenly, the dreams become questions, the questions become challenges, and the challenges become too much of a hassle. It's already difficult enough to recognize an opportunity, but acting on it for real is the hard part.

Only a small minority will take the first steps. They'll put in the work, and as they learn, they will soon realize that what seemed easy is actually 20, 50, or even 100 times harder than they expected. You will have to experience it yourself, but I have learned that starting and continuously working on a project is always more challenging than we think—sometimes by orders of magnitude. This is where innovation often dies: before it even begins.

Take, for example, one of my failed projects, *DayDay*. In the beginning, it all looked like an exciting venture; we wanted to create a desktop status mini-map where you could see the status of your work colleagues and know if they are online, offline, or busy. You could even join anyone else in a virtual meeting directly from the mini-map. The beauty of this idea was that it would allow collaboration between 2D and 3D worlds, between people on a screen and users using virtual and augmented reality headsets.

We partnered with an incubator in Frankfurt that would assume the technical part of the job, coding the entire tool and raising the funds. On our side, we could design the concepts, screens, and 3D models for the collaborative spaces; we even quickly prototyped how the spaces would feel using existing VR platforms. Everything felt possible! The first months went by, and we realized that we had picked a job that was orders of magnitude above our level: we had to figure out new operative systems, handle data securely yet fast enough, manage all sorts of document types in 2D and 3D, run servers, and much more. In retrospect, it's easy to see a thousand other ways how this could have failed, but the honest answer is that back then, we got scared by the massive amount of work needed just to build the first demo version of our product. We mainly failed because we didn’t recognize that we didn’t have the needed resources nor the indestructible motivation to continue engaging in action.

Innovation happens when opportunity meets action, but action means long-term, sustained, and focused work that only truly motivated and invested innovators can persevere with. You have only so many moments of truth you are aware of, and we could argue that they don’t even count if you don’t take action and make them happen. So far, I’ve had a couple of dozen moments of truth. They feel like epiphanies; depending on your perspective, you might find them plentiful or limited. Experiencing a lot and running into new and funny situations will help you find yours. Reflecting on this, I think this is, in part, the reason why I’ve found myself dancing with children and monks in the Indian Himalayas, speeding away from massive storms on the high seas, flying across the world to meet “internet friends,” and being in Ukraine during the war. Maybe I’m just embracing new situations in search of opportunities, knowledge, and wisdom.

Another interesting thought I’ve been reflecting on in recent years is that it feels impossible to rush and trigger your moments of truth. In practical terms, you are more likely to increase the probability of them happening anytime by exposing yourself to more situations. Still, I haven’t found a way to trigger them at will. Suppose you experience many heterogeneous activities in your personal and business life while still keeping an area of expertise. In that case, you can create a greater chance to experience moments of truth. While the opportunities we have available in life feel infinite, epiphanies and moments of truth don't happen every day—they are limited. If we hope to spark massive change in any area, we should dedicate much of our time and resources to the opportunities that matter. Therefore, you want to keep a balance between saying "yes" to new experiences and saying "no" to non-relevant ones so as not to spread yourself too thin.

One more realization I had about the moments of truth is that they are not all about business, career, or innovation but personal development. As you progress through the chapters, I hope you slowly adopt the idea that innovation is more about us humans and how we approach the problems we face instead of some chronological steps, checklists, or frameworks. With this in mind, the moments of truth can be both awakening and enlightening. In fact, my first moment of truth was in a dire situation, a short moment that shaped my character and defined the course for the rest of my life. This is a story I have never told before.

It was a sunny day in El Salvador. My family and some friends decided to spend the day at the beach. Nothing suggested this would be an unusual day; it was just pleasant and calm: The beautiful dancing palms, the smell of the sea, the savory taste of the seafood, the harmonious sound of the waves, and the soft sand under my feet—it was perfect. Later in the day, our guests from Europe and Latin America wanted to go for a swim, and we went together. We were enjoying the waist-high water just a dozen meters from the shore. After a few minutes, I noticed one of my friends had drifted several meters away from the group.

"Come join us, don’t stay too far!" I shouted, waving at him. He nodded and began swimming toward us, and I turned back to the waves. Half a minute later, I glanced back—he hadn’t moved. For a second, I was confused, but then I thought that maybe my friend was in a rip current. He looked tired, so we began moving toward him, walking parallel to the shore. We walked most of the way, and the water was at hip height. We weren’t in danger, but as we got closer to him, I felt a sudden drop into deeper waters and stepped back instantly. Our friend was just a couple of meters (a few feet) away from the shallow waters where we were standing. So, we formed a human chain to attempt to pull him out. The smallest would go in the front, and we started grabbing from each other's arms. Our human chain stretched all the way to the back, where the biggest guy, a friend of a friend, anchored the line. In a blink of impatience, the big guy pushed his way to the front, and as soon as he did, he sank into the deeper water. We felt his heavy weight pulling all of us down with him into the rip current—panic set in.

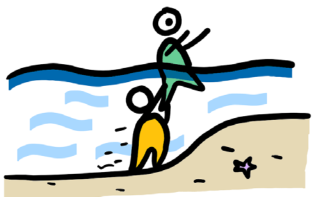
In an instant, our day at the beach turned into chaos. Five of us were now caught in the current. Two of my friends escaped almost immediately, and one of them started running back to shore to get us help. Suddenly, I felt the pain of salty water going down my throat, and I wasn't just drowning—I was being slammed underwater, again and again, by a brutal force, and this is when I finally heard the big guy say: "Can't… grlbglb… swim!" His fear translated into uncoordinated, violent movements as he flailed his arms and legs in every direction. With every desperate kick and push, his weight and strength forced us deeper. It wasn't just panic—it was complete terror. His heavy arms and legs kept pushing me down with brutal force as I fought to keep us afloat.

Miraculously, my friend, who had been caught in the current, finally reached a shallow spot. I felt a small and brief relief, but the punches, kicks, the now unharmonious waves going over my head, and the salty water in my mouth reminded me where I was—reality hit hard. I was still being dragged under, my energy depleting fast with every hit and gulp of seawater. "It’s just the two of us now," I thought. And somehow, time slowed down. My survival instincts took over, and the darkest thought I ever had crossed my mind: "I can swim away."

Call me downright crazy, but in those few seconds, I saw a future where life had lost all its color. I pictured myself at a silent dinner with my family; the food was tasteless, and our faces were empty. We were never happy again. At that moment, I knew I had no choice: I had to do whatever it took or die trying. I thought there might be a solution—I just didn’t know what it was yet, but time was running out.

In the middle of that violent yet slowed-down moment, I unexpectedly reached a state of serene calmness—ataraxia. All noise went silent, and all pain was suppressed; nothing could have distracted me. I stopped fighting for a second and let his weight sink me further, giving me a brief moment to think. First, he pushed me down with his hands, and as I submerged more, I felt him kicking and pushing me with his feet, but it didn’t hurt anymore. Suddenly, my toes felt something soft yet a bit solid—sand!

We were drowning in just under 3 meters (9.8 feet) of water! Time accelerated back to normal, and the solution became crystal clear. I propelled myself up with the force of my legs, took a deep breath, and dove straight to the ocean floor. I grabbed him by the legs and pushed him up, using his weight to give me traction. Step by step and moving underwater, I lifted him and walked us through the current and into the shallow waters.



Looking back, I know this was the most defining moment of my life. It wasn't just a life-or-death situation—it was my most intense moment of truth, one that still empowers me today. When you block out the noise, you can find the signal.

Moments of truth define who we are. They offer us the chance to gain wisdom faster than anything else. After that day, everything became simpler—life became more enjoyable. Just like in a video game, that day, I unlocked the ability to fully commit to my decisions, and for the first time, I made peace with death. I've been anxious and stressed many times since then, but I've never been truly scared ever since. Moments of truth are pivotal. They can change everything—whether it's embarking on a new project or surviving a dangerous situation, recognizing them and acting with determination early are the two takeaways I can share.

What are your moments of truth? How do you recognize them? And how do you stay motivated enough to see them through? In my experience, these are questions that can be answered more easily when you narrow your life down in a preferred direction. In his best-selling book, *The subtle art of not giving a f*ck*, Mark Manson teaches us that we should ignore and not care about most things—but we should totally care about the things that truly matter to us. We find true fulfillment by embracing life's inevitable challenges and letting go of unnecessary worries and societal expectations. Manson’s approach is essential for differentiating between problems that we should solve and those that shouldn’t concern us.

The longer we live, the more challenges we will face, and the more lessons will humble us. Every difficult moment we survive makes us stronger, preparing us for even greater challenges. Sometimes, we must make tough decisions with limited time or information, but if you pick a problem, an area of focus—something you’re driven to solve—and truly pour your energy into it, you’ll rely less on luck when your moment of truth comes. You’ll be ready, armed with the knowledge and wisdom you’ve gathered along the way.

So, how can you prepare for your own moments of truth? If you want to try what worked for me, then you can surround yourself with diverse experiences and continuously seek more knowledge. You can pursue challenges in your area of passion, and when the moment arrives—you will act without hesitation. More than anything, you want to be mentally and emotionally ready so that when opportunity knocks, you will already be prepared to answer.

Yes, the risks are real, and success isn't guaranteed, but if you obsess about solving the right problems for you, you'll be prepared when your moment of truth comes. Don’t wait for the perfect moment—be ready when any moment of truth arrives.

4. INNOVATION AS A STATE OF MIND

So far, we've navigated creative chaos, seen how acceleration distorts our measuring systems, and faced the pressure of living the moments of truth. If you haven't noticed by now, this book isn't meant to teach you rigid methods or neatly packaged "innovation frameworks." Innovation is far more about culture, mindset, and human behavior than it is about structures or processes.

Now, it's time to explore an unconventional view of innovation—not as a toolset or a collection of strategies, as every other "innovation book" might tell you—but as a dynamic state of mind. Innovation doesn't happen outside of us; it's something we activate within when driven by a sense of purpose and the urge "to do something."

Each of us has an "inner genius" waiting to be awakened, but it often lies dormant. The challenge is to awaken, sustain, and convert each moment into meaningful action. These moments are bursts of intellectual energy, where ideas become actions at an accelerated rate. They can occur multiple times a day and can even be stimulated under the right conditions. Unlike the rare, life-changing moments of truth that come uninvited and shift the course of our lives, these bursts of creative energy are like frequent speed boosts that propel us forward on our journey.

To unleash this inner genius and embrace innovation, it helps to first find a cause that deeply motivates you and pushes you to continuously strive for improvement. Without this driving force, you risk slipping into perpetual conformity. For many of us, execution without a positive impact on society is unlikely to allow us to grow and be happy. Therefore, you should actively surround yourself with people who inspire you—those with positive attitudes and experience solving significant challenges. Their mindset will influence you, fueling your innovative drive, and you can learn from them how to embrace failure as part of the process. Lastly, you must convert your knowledge into tangible action since ideas that aren't implemented are no different from ideas that were never conceived.

Innovation is a fragile, temporary, and unstable state of mind. Once you tap into it, you must recognize it for what it is and exploit it fully—put it to use. While many books discuss innovation in terms of corporate strategy or structured processes, I argue that innovation is about you—operating at your highest potential.

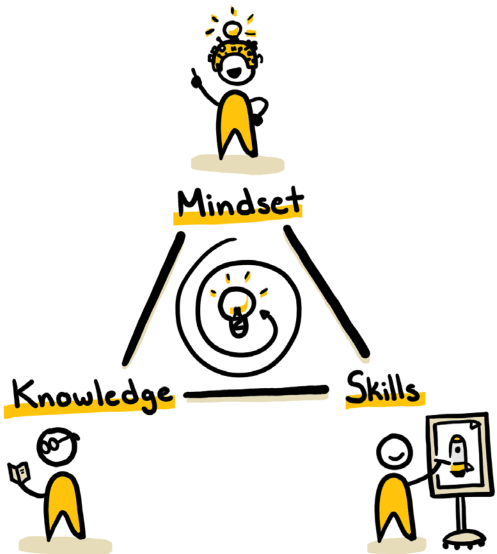
The next time you face a big problem requiring creative solutions, remember this: every solution is born in the mind before it takes shape in action. If you and your values are sound, connected to the world, professionally skilled, and inspired, you'll be equipped to face any challenge with an innovative mindset. When those challenges come, let your mindset and values guide you, and don't let yourself be governed by metrics, rigid frameworks, or non-innovators' opinions. Evaluate the situation, weigh your knowledge and resources, and act.

Being more knowledgeable and open to new ideas indeed leads to greater creativity, which is linked to innovation, but here's the catch: it's easy to get trapped in the creator's dilemma. Starting something new is always exciting; the early stages can be fun, but soon enough, you'll encounter scalability problems, cashflow issues, legal hurdles, and repetitive work that feels more like a grind than innovation.

You need discipline and balance to avoid getting caught in the loop of constantly jumping from one new idea to the next. If you're highly creative and frequently shift projects in a short time, consider that true innovation occurs when you dedicate more time and effort to the projects that matter most. It's about asking yourself whether you did "what it takes" to finish the job rather than simply doing "your best." More often than not, doing your best isn't enough—you must do more. You need to push through the tough moments and keep going for longer than you feel comfortable. The temptation to abandon a project when things get hard is strong, but true innovation requires seeing it through. Think of your projects like children: don't leave them without your care at age three just because they can't run yet. You didn't stay long enough to teach them how to walk! Be responsible, and don't ditch your project. If you need motivation, reflect on the vision or dream that first inspired you to start. Have you achieved that yet? No? Then finish it!

On the other hand, many people get too comfortable with what they know and what they do. If this sounds familiar, you should build a habit of pushing yourself into discomfort. Start small by deliberately breaking parts of your routine, little by little. Do you always eat at the same restaurant? Try somewhere new. Do you stick to the same tasks at work? Ask your boss if you can spend one day a week learning what your colleagues in other departments do. The more you break your routine and seek new challenges, the more likely you'll crave knowledge and growth. As you learn and grow, you'll develop a hunger for discovery that will push you further outside your comfort zone.

At the end of the day, you can't fully control your surroundings or your background, and you certainly can't predict when your moments of truth will strike. However, you can commit to cultivating—what, in my experience, are—the innovator's three most important traits: Mindset, Knowledge, and Skills.



If you want to become one with innovation, it must become your way of life. In the following pages, we'll explore how to adopt the right mindset, gain relevant knowledge, and develop the necessary skills to build your dreams.

4.1 MINDSET

Mindset as a topic can be tricky, especially if we define innovation as a state of mind. That perspective ties mindset to every concept in this book—and rightly so! Mindset has everything to do with innovation! Here, I aim to share the mindset characteristics you can adopt to navigate chaos, acceleration, moments of truth, and the *Unavoidables*.

Have you ever had an idea suddenly pop into your mind? Maybe it caught you while showering, cleaning the house, or even answering nature's call. I bet you have! However, just as quickly as they come, most ideas fade into the void, never to return. Other times, it sticks, bugs you, and you feel the urge to know more and the need to act. Then, it's no longer an idea; it's a dream, and since you projected it inside your brain, you already visualize it halfway. With proper time and effort, it can most likely be realized. However, as an aspiring innovator, you need to understand certain concepts; these are not rules or anything; these are just ways of thinking that will help you increase the probability of "making it."

To the trained innovator, an idea means nothing. Ideas come and go all the time; they are abundant. To tell the truth, at some points, you have half a dozen new ideas every day, but everything you need to decide is to prioritize or suppress them. An idea holds no value until you allocate some time to it. You can do this by visualizing it, writing its concept down, and working on it. The issue is that it's not enough for the idea to hold value for you; others, especially potential customers or users, should also see its value. An idea is more likely to hold value for others if it addresses a real problem they face. The bigger the pain, the bigger the value.

As you move forward, the focus shifts from the idea to the problem and the optimal ways to solve it. In this venture, you move from idea to idea until the problem is solved! Every failed attempt teaches you one more way not to solve it! The right mindset is to recognize that changing your ideas as you fail and learn is perfectly acceptable, at least as long as you continue to build expertise in solving similar problems. You have to try again and again until you finally make it. Hopefully, in this quest, you are already adding value to other people's lives and generating revenue that allows you to solve the problem even more effectively. The concept is to filter out ideas and focus on one that solves a problem relevant to you or someone you know; this will give you purpose and the motivation to weather any storm. The second takeaway is to aim to create enormous value, and enough value will most likely come back to you.

If you want to improve your chances on your innovative journey, don't fall in love with your ideas. In fact, kill the first idea, the second, and even the third. The best ideas usually aren't the first ones. Innovation often requires extensive input and numerous iterations to succeed. Give yourself enough time and space to develop better ideas. If you are journaling, I expect you to write something along the lines: "Dear diary, on my 21st try, my team and I finally made it. It's been over two years since we started, but once I show this to the world, it will change it forever!" You will have to access and develop your critical thinking skills so that you don't lie to yourself about the status of your project. Being honest with yourself allows you to see your work for what it is; if it lacks the expected quality, return to the drawing board.

As you explore, you should prospect other ideas, projects, technologies, trends, or industries for more input and inspiration. Consider that the synthesis process we learned in Chapter 1 compounds in value when you have more valuable input. An easy way to continue getting input without feeling like work is to engage in hobbies that might be close to your project, but we will briefly cover this particular part soon. One thing to remember is that comparing your project's progress to other successful projects can lead to jealousy and demotivation.

As you learned in *Unmeasurable Acceleration*, most innovation happens in the shadows. That means you have no idea how much work went into the other, more successful projects; you don't know what other founders had to sacrifice to be where they are; you only see the success. The journey is hard enough to be getting discouraged over false expectations. However, you should regularly check what your competitors do to ensure you do something better than them.

As an innovator, it helps immensely to visualize your ideas from the very beginning. Start with a sketch and prototype it using one of the many AIs in the market. Make your idea as tangible as possible to show it to potential customers and see if it can create value.

Take, for example, “Spark Hub,” a project I made while still an emerging entrepreneur. While working for a large corporation, I wanted to build a functional innovation room—a space for executing workshops, visualizing ideas, building prototypes, and testing assumptions. At that time, my employer provided me with a small room and a budget of $1,000 to “be creative” and set up an innovation room. Needless to say, I wasn’t happy with the result. While the new room was undoubtedly an improvement over the original and became functional, it still fell short of my vision.

At this point, I’ve visited almost every relevant "innovation lab" in Germany. Some of these labs cost millions to build, but I quickly saw through the facade—most were just show-off rooms, not functional innovation rooms. I wanted to see the real deal; I wanted to build a room where real creators could build things and where all the cool technology is not "protected" behind a glass container. So, my urge didn't leave me, and a few months later, I quit my job as an innovation manager and started my first company and innovation agency, *WeSpark*.

After a year of hard work and saving, the desire to build an innovation center resurfaced. The difference is that I didn't have to ask for permission or request a budget this time, as I would pay from my own wallet. I just knew I needed to see my dream with my own eyes, not just a foggy version. The most complex challenge was finding the space to build the idea; at this point in time, I couldn't afford to rent an ample space myself, mainly since the risk of not being able to fill the room during the pandemic times was higher than ever. This didn't deter me, so I went to a well-known co-working space, requested to see their largest office, found one I liked, and 3D scanned it with my phone. I printed the scan on a sheet of paper and sketched the idea:

With the initial sketch, I aimed to visualize the idea as if it were already built. We even chose a larger room than we initially considered. Ultimately, we would either get a bigger room or nothing; going big was no additional risk. So, I asked the space manager: “Would you support me if I build an innovation lab that will attract new tenants to your co-working space?”. I showed him a 3D-rendered room model and said, “Everyone in Frankfurt will know that if they want to innovate, they must come here.”

In short, we began negotiations and eventually received approval to pilot-test the idea for a year. My team and I had a lot of fun furnishing and decorating the room. I especially enjoyed setting up all the technical gadgets; it felt like I owned a mini-*Disneyland*. We had everything possible: VR headsets, a professional studio setup, a podcast room, powerful PCs, 3D printers, lightsabers, skateboards, drawing pads, and lots of prototyping material.

We had many visitors over the months and managed to do many recordings, prototyping sessions, workshops, and more. Primarily, we attracted entrepreneurs and, on special occasions, ambassadors and politicians, too. Doing this during the pandemic was scary, but not trying and regretting it would have been permanently scarier. The long-term plan of being more flexible and traveling more didn't fit with running the place, but I still think it was worth the try, and I still have the following picture as a living memory and evidence that whatever I imagine, I can build. That's the innovation spirit!

Very much like the story building the Spark Hub, when you are confronted with the decision on what to do, don't do what feels safe or what is generally accepted. It's rare to spark innovation by following the crowd. To drive innovation and create impact, focus on gaining expertise in one field, then be right when everyone else is wrong. That's how you innovate! Imagine you want to take a trip to get inspiration for an art-related startup and create something unique. Then don't go to Paris! You want to find one of those countries where you most likely need a visa and where you will be the only foreigner. In those places, you have a higher chance of discovering unique cultural inspiration that no one else has!

Assuming you build something new—a concept others are unfamiliar with—the next step is to gather feedback.

You want to start validating early enough to ensure you build a product that solves a problem from the beginning. As you iterate on your invention, you should add more feedback rounds every time you make significant progress, but you can validate your ideas even before you build a prototype. My favorite example is from my entrepreneur friends Daniela and Lukas, who sent me a single text message over the phone with a few questions:

They told me that they got over 40 replies by the second day. There was no need to schedule a meeting or anything else; this was as simple as I could imagine. To get constructive feedback, you can ask many things, but some valuable questions are: Do you have this problem? Does this product solve your problem? Would you pay for it? How much would you pay for it? If there was only one feature that you could keep, which would it be and why? If we had to remove one feature, which one wouldn't affect you? Would you recommend this to anyone you know? Answering these powerful questions will provide you with targeted knowledge to solve critical problems. The alternative—relying on assumptions and making decisions in ignorance—risks failure. Since this is my first time writing a book, I will make sure to follow my own advice and ask for your feedback at the end of it—thank you in advance!

Going from an idea to a built solution can be a long process. Some industries, such as the aircraft or pharmaceutical industries, require more time, as they might require meticulous testing. However, even within the most bureaucratic industries, there are always potential innovations where you can move and develop fast because they don't touch critical areas of the business. It is usually a step-by-step process regardless of where you try to innovate. Each day and week, you must prioritize your work to build momentum. Some days might be fantastic, and others will be brutally humbling, but if you have strong incentives, you will learn how to fail while moving forward. Your mindset should always aim and act towards success while still preparing for failure, but this is a topic that we will unavoidably cover in a dedicated chapter.

Finally, as an innovator, you will naturally become an untamable rule-breaker, a freedom seeker, and a portal builder of the dimensions of your creation. You don't follow social constructs; you build them, you create a better world. You develop technologies, products, and services that upgrade other people's lives. You will break things already in place, and on top of them, you will build a better version of it. Simultaneously, you will have to fight many temptations, like easy cash grabs, dubious opportunities, and difficult moral decisions. A genuine innovator goes into risk and remains incorruptible. Still, to do this, you have to nurture your critical thinking and sacrifice many pleasures before allowing yourself to enjoy any distractions.

In *The Bitcoin Standard*, Saifedean Ammous describes "low-time preference" as the ability to delay immediate gratification for long-term gains. It's about prioritizing the future over the present, investing time and effort for more significant rewards later in life. On the other hand, "high-time preference" focuses on short-term rewards, sacrificing future prosperity for immediate pleasure. When applied to innovation, adopting a low-time preference mindset is crucial. True innovators think about long-term impact and sustainability, resisting the urge for quick wins. We have to be patient, persistent, and willing to endure the grind for years because we learned that the most extraordinary breakthroughs often take longer to manifest fully.

So, do yourself a favor and unfry your brain. Choose a low-time preference and delete the social media apps to stop the brainless scrolling. If you poison your brain with a chronic dopamine overdose, you will unlikely be able to convince yourself to do the demanding tasks that are needed to innovate.

In pursuing a project with the potential to change the world, you must be willing to sacrifice less relevant activities. Whether allowing too much comfort to dominate your life or wasting time on distractions like watching TikToks, binge-watching Netflix, and exploring Twitter/X, these sacrifices are necessary to stay focused on solving the problem you chose. Be sure that no rewards are guaranteed, and any that come will likely be far in the future. Yet, this is the mindset you must adopt—one that is driven by purpose rather than immediate gratification and one that understands the value of patience in the long game of innovation.

4.2 KNOWLEDGE

In the fast-paced world of innovation, knowledge isn't just power—it's survival. With the right insights and expertise, you can navigate uncertainty, seize opportunities, and rise above the chaos. Choosing to learn is a decision that's hard to get wrong; when you learn a new concept, no one can take that away from you; it's yours to remember and yours to apply whenever it fits. Knowledge reveals opportunities and helps you understand the pros and cons of your choices. Sometimes, it will let you see the end of the road before you get there. Without it, you are at the mercy of whatever life throws at you, and you learned earlier that life is unfair. However, accumulating knowledge doesn't mean knowing everything about everything. It's about acquiring the right knowledge that directly impacts your ability to solve problems and make informed project decisions.

You don't need to master every field; just recognize when and where expertise is needed—and pursue it. This is where critical thinking comes in. It's not just about gathering knowledge; it's about questioning, analyzing, and making decisions. With critical thinking, you can cut through the noise and apply knowledge to fuel real innovation.

While critical thinking helps you filter and apply knowledge, it's essential to understand that knowledge is not just information. Proper knowledge transforms the way you act and think. As Epictetus, a famous Greek Stoic philosopher, once said, “Only the educated are free.” He believed true freedom comes from knowledge and self-understanding. For Epictetus, education wasn’t just formal schooling but the cultivation of wisdom, self-discipline, and critical thinking. Being "educated" means knowing how to face life’s challenges without being enslaved by external circumstances, emotions, or desires. If you lack education in this sense, you are often controlled by your impulses, fears, and ignorance. Just imagine what would happen to your innovation project if you acted on impulse, how many times you would quit out of fear, and how irresponsible it would be to lead your project ignorant of what’s happening in the world. Even if you are “free” in a physical or societal sense, you will be bound by mental and emotional chains. However, if you develop the ability to reason and reflect, you will be free to decide how to tackle your challenges without letting external influences decide for you.

Part of an innovator’s reflection is to understand what we don’t know. One of the most frequent biases and pitfalls is overestimating our knowledge, judging too quickly, and thinking that our assumptions are right. The challenge is revisiting familiar topics with fresh eyes. In his talk *Introduction to Bitcoin: what is Bitcoin and why does it matter?* Andreas Antonopoulos tells how he discovered Bitcoin in 2011 and ultimately dismissed it because it was related to gambling—or at least he thought so. Later, in 2012, he finally read Bitcoin's technical publication, commonly known as the *Bitcoin Whitepaper*. Antonopoulos argues that, thanks to his technical background and his conscious decision to revisit Bitcoin and learn about it, he was able to uncover the true value of the technology: "My background in computer science and distributed systems allowed me to see behind the illusion of what I thought Bitcoin was, and it blew my mind." Consequently, he went into a state of absolute obsession, to the point that he barely ate or did anything else besides learning Bitcoin for four months straight, losing 12kg (26 pounds) in the process. As of today, Andreas has dedicated his career to learning and teaching Bitcoin full-time. This example is the embodiment of the moments of truth, showing both successful identification and committed action. The lesson here is that knowledge opens doors to accessing and acquiring more knowledge; if he didn't have the technical background that allowed him to understand the mechanics described on the whitepaper, then he would have likely dismissed the technology again.

In Chapter 2, we explored the idea that, for most of us, it's nearly impossible to master everything, even within a single industry or technology. Antonopoulos explains that the learning process continues forever as he finds new layers of depth to understand the topic, and both programmers and entrepreneurs keep adding new updates and use cases. Because becoming a truth expert can take a lifetime of learning, you need to consciously pick your area of focus and interest. You should always dedicate enough time to grasp the basics of a new topic; my personal advice is to invest close to 40 hours in learning the new topic before judging it too fast.

Once you've begun acquiring knowledge, the next step is understanding how to learn effectively—and sometimes, this means unlearning what you thought you knew. Imagine for a second that you are building a house of cards. You carefully balance two cards together to form a triangle, then balance the next two into a second triangle. You then bridge both with a card between the tops before repeating this process multiple times. Learning is like building a house of cards: your first exposure to a topic lays the foundation, and every new piece of knowledge builds carefully on the last. It is like learning basic math—the foundation—before completing algebra.

The problem is that sometimes you have to unlearn before you can continue building, which means removing foundational cards without collapsing the entire structure. This process of unthinking and unlearning applies to everything from your beliefs and sports techniques to your opinion on whether butter is healthy or harmful for your body. Once you place the first pairs of cards and form a foundation, removing the base cards nearly always collapses the entire structure. Whether caused by cognitive biases like confirmation bias or the sunk cost fallacy, rethinking and having a fresh perspective on a topic will require you to remove some of those first cards used for the foundation. This might mean everything you believe about a topic could be false if your sources are unreliable. You don’t want your beliefs nor your life work to come down, falling like a house of cards, but sometimes you must do what it takes, and more often than not, what it takes is to unlearn.

Luckily for us, it’s possible to change and even override our knowledge, beliefs, behaviors, and even skills. You just need to know that it requires significantly more work and self-discipline to unlearn than to learn. To be a genuine innovator, accept that you’re sometimes wrong and stay open-minded enough to change.

To add insult to injury, starting to learn a new topic is often easy. You progress fast through the basics and start to build your foundation. You've heard “you are what you eat,” meaning we should eat healthily, and if we apply this to the topic of knowledge, then we get “what you learn is what you think.” Choose your sources carefully, or you may waste time correcting your thinking—or risk becoming the “flat-earther” of your industry. Remember, learning at first is easy; unlearning is always hard.

Assuming that you have the right sources, remember that acquiring knowledge is easy at first until it becomes moderately difficult. Eventually, advanced knowledge about the topic becomes scarce or lies behind a paywall. This is when you need to push through. At this point, decide if you want rare knowledge that enables you to build what few others can. Fortunately, we live in an era where we can easily store and access almost all human knowledge. Back in the mid-'90s, when I was a small kid, my father got me *Microsoft Encarta*, a digital multimedia encyclopedia that I had installed on my computer. I was always amazed at how you could discover and click through the different topics following the links on each page. I would start reading about lions, then click and read about the savannah, Africa, Asia, monks, etc. Still, I would often hit a roadblock when some topic wasn't clickable, eventually stopping my curiosity. Today, we have AI capable of gathering information from across the internet indefinitely.

While AI is undeniably incredible and potentially one of the most significant technological breakthroughs, it can be detrimental to your mind. Whether it is a blessing or a curse will depend on how you use AI. Don't outsource your critical thinking by over-relying on AI to make decisions for you. A principle proposed by Canadian psychologist Donald Hebb (1949) suggests that when two brain cells are activated together repeatedly, the connection between them becomes stronger: "Neurons that fire together, wire together." This means that repeating activities like critical thinking naturally strengthens your competence. Therefore, try changing how you use AI by asking it to challenge your thoughts or asking you challenging questions (without the answers) to help you rethink your approach, but do the thinking yourself!

If you rely on AI for critical thinking, the lack of reinforcement can weaken your neural connections, and your instincts might play a more active role, such as acting on the impulses of fear. As of this writing, predictive Artificial Intelligence models are based on all the digitally documented information from humankind's past data; they neither perceive nor understand the world as we do, and since you are trying to take your venture where no one has gone before, you will have to think as no one has done before. Still, at some point, we will have access to better AI models, such as the Active Inference Artificial Intelligence proposed by renowned neuro-scientist Karl Friston, which gathers sensory data in real-time and attempts to mimic the cognitive processes of nature. Until we get there, doing the hard mental work and succeeding can often be more rewarding than the outcome, but finding the right balance of using AI is very personal, and you will have to find your own.

You must remember how easily we can be manipulated and deceived if we have the wrong information sources.

Avoid accepting information at face value, be critical about every source of information, and question it all. The internet and tech advances provide abundant tools to gather knowledge and advance our projects. Understand how to use technology effectively rather than risk being manipulated by its designers.

Once, I caught myself looking with blame at the hammer in my hand after hitting my thumb while trying to nail a picture on the wall. Blaming the hammer makes no sense—it's just a tool, but what if some of today's popular tools were like an AI-powered hammer owned by a first-aid-kit company? If you hit your thumb, there's a reason to distrust the hammer maker, and you would be right to blame the hammer.

When searching for topics on social media, algorithms often prioritize sensational posts over the deeper, complex information you might need. It would be like a hammer designed to hit your thumb—and never the nail. Consider alternative platforms if you still want to socialize and get news from social media. You can look into the open-source, decentralized social media based on the *NOSTR* protocol. Though still an emerging technology, it's already home to solid, future-focused discussions. You will no longer be exposed to algorithms trying to show targeted ads or keep you scrolling indefinitely.

The content that you interact with online will, through cookies, algorithms, and AI, dictate what sort of content you are exposed to, and very much like this, the people closest to you will influence what you learn and how you act. If you want to adopt the mindset of an innovator and if you want to listen and learn more about the trending technologies out there, you will want to spend more time with people who think alike.

Over the past few years, my top sources of knowledge and inspiration have been chat groups with people pursuing similar goals. I’m in multiple groups with entrepreneurs, geeks, creators, developers, Bitcoiners, and even a neat, signal-first, closed group with philosophers who combine all the above. In the past months, thanks to the passion and goodwill of other group participants, I’ve discovered AI tools that allowed me to build new digital products whenever I want. I also learned about *Masterminds* and was introduced to new philosophical ways of approaching life.

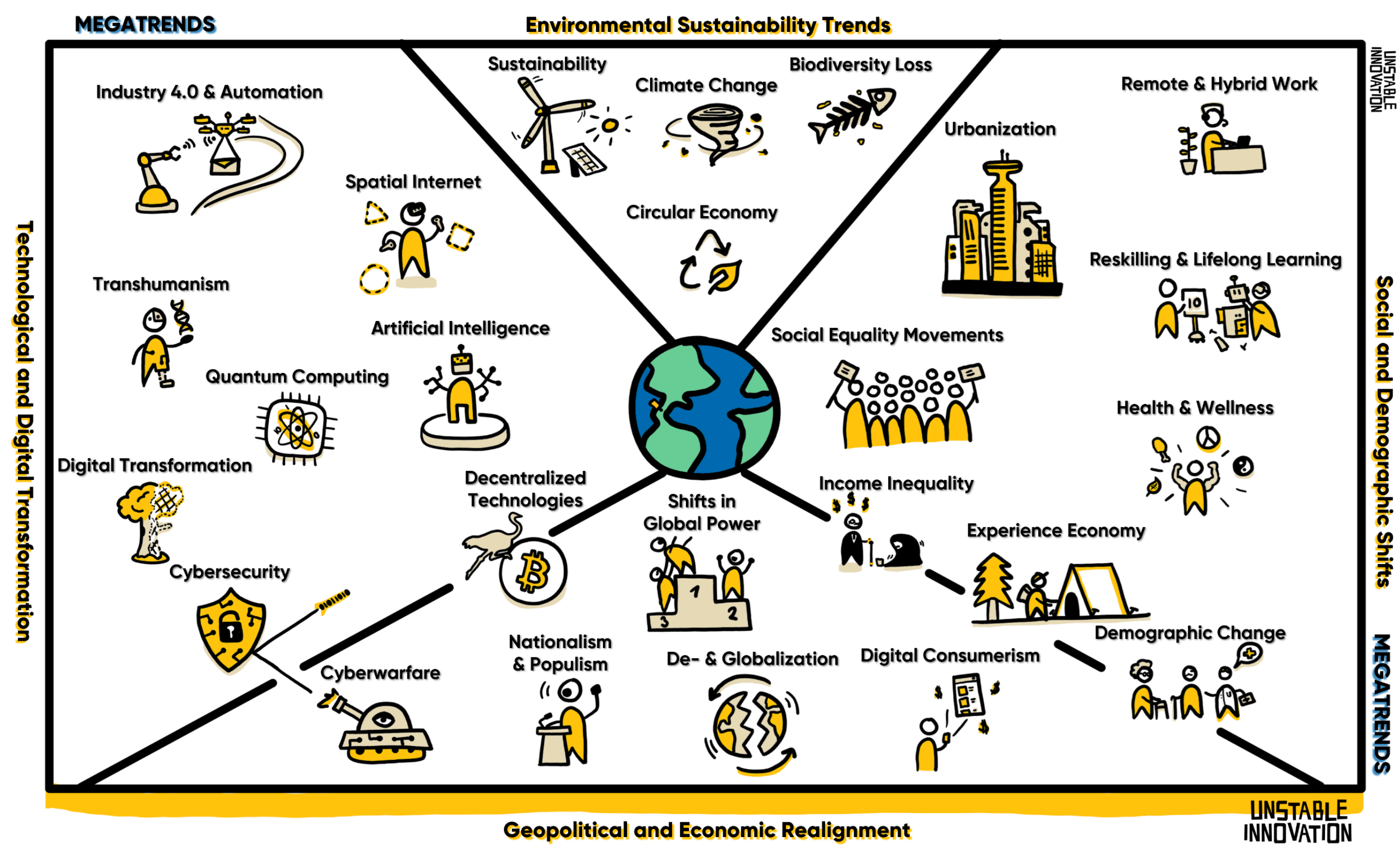
Every message is worth my time, and naturally, I share every experiment I make when testing out any shared knowledge. After being invited, I joined the group to give and share and not to take, but inherently, as there are more people in the group, there is always more knowledge shared there than I can contribute, and the whole group grows together. In short, being among innovators will likely help you become one.

MEGATRENDS

Of all the topics you could explore, Megatrends offer a clear path to understanding the future. These large-scale forces of change shape industries, societies, and economies, creating a strong foundation for innovation. Aspiring innovators should at least have a basic understanding of the ongoing Megatrends. This will help you avoid being caught off guard by major shifts and even give you the chance to predict when these forces might have a global impact—potentially turning them to your advantage.

The next section might seem like a dry overview of upcoming technological advances and social changes, but that's okay. *Feel free to skim through the following pages and focus on what grabs your attention*. You don't need to master everything—in fact, you shouldn't—but you can achieve greatness by honing in on areas that spark your curiosity. Identify the disruptive trends in your field of interest and get ready for what's ahead.

At the end of the book, you'll find updated *Resources and Links* to stay current with the latest Megatrends. Keep in mind that trends don't exist in isolation. They often overlap and combine, leading to even more opportunities for innovation through synthesis. Now, let's have a look at the Megatrends Map:


MEGATRENDS
Environmental Sustainability Trends
Sustainability
Climate Change
Biodiversity Loss
Circular Economy
Industry 4.0 & Automation
Spatial Internet
Transhumanism
Artificial Intelligence
Quantum Computing
Digital Transformation
Decentralized Technologies
Cybersecurity
Cyberwarfare
Urbanization
Remote & Hybrid Work
Reskilling & Lifelong Learning
Social Equality Movements
Health & Wellness
Income Inequality
Experience Economy
Shifts in Global Power
Nationalism & Populism
De- & Globalization
Digital Consumerism
Demographic Change
Technological and Digital Transformation
Social and Demographic Shifts
MEGATRENDS
Geopolitical and Economic Realignment
UNSTABLE INNOVATION

In the map, four categories encapsulate all Megatrends transforming every aspect of our private and business world: Technological Transformation, Environmental Trends, Social Shifts, and Economic Realignment.

TECHNOLOGICAL AND DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION

Technology is reshaping the world faster than ever, simultaneously affecting all other social, environmental, and economic Megatrends. AI and automation are the main forces of change and will continue compounding advancement and accelerating in the foreseeable future. These technologies promise to revolutionize our views on everything in ways we are just beginning to understand.

Artificial Intelligence: AI needs no introduction; it is a present topic in all news. It is taking over the internet, and today, it has already transformed entire industries by taking over and automating complex decision-making processes, analyzing vast datasets, and optimizing operations. From healthcare to finance, virtually every industry is experiencing how AI is increasing efficiency while reshaping and sometimes even replacing human roles in the workplace.

Automation and Industry 4.0: Whether you imagine a factory full of robots and machines that communicate with each other or entire fleets of terrestrial, airborne, and nautical vehicles that autonomously navigate changing circumstances while moving towards their goal, all these trends are part of the Automation movement. It enables machines to take over repetitive and labor-intensive tasks and improves industry productivity for physical-related tasks.

Digital Transformation: The shift from non-digital to digital operations has become a necessity for survival in today's economy. Any serious company has to adopt the ways of the digital era in one way or another to stay competitive or face the pressure of more efficient competition empowered with tools, cloud computing, or even AI.

Cybersecurity: As more business activities and personal data move online, cybersecurity has become a critical component of digital infrastructure. Cyberattacks are growing exponentially in frequency and sophistication, making security an essential focus for governments, enterprises, and individuals alike. Here is a friendly reminder to *keep your software up to date*.

Quantum Computing: Quantum technology holds the potential to solve problems far beyond the capability of classical computers. Though still emerging, it promises breakthroughs in areas where processing extremely large numbers matters, for example, in cryptography, material science, and drug discovery.

Decentralized Technologies: Blockchain technology is enabling several decentralized solutions that eliminate intermediaries and enhance finance, governance, and supply chain transparency. Applications like Bitcoin as an alternative to the current monetary system, or *NOSTR* as a substitute for corporate-owned social media platforms, are pushing the boundaries of how value and information are exchanged.

Transhumanism: As gen-tech and wearable technology continue to increase in power while decreasing in price, Transhumanism gains momentum. It explores the enhancement of human physical and cognitive abilities through technology, such as genetic engineering, brain-computer interfaces, and bionics. Though still an emerging field, it envisions a future where technology can radically augment or alter what it means to be human, challenging our complete understanding of life, ethics, and human potential.

Spatial Internet: The spatial internet, also known as augmented reality (AR) and virtual reality (VR), merges the physical and digital worlds, allowing users to interact with digital environments in real-time. This technology reshapes gaming, healthcare, education, and retail industries, offering immersive 3D experiences beyond traditional screens. As it evolves, the spatial internet is set to redefine how we interact with data, objects, and people in both personal and professional contexts. With new protocols such as *HSTP*, this could become the next era of the internet.

Environmental Sustainability Trends

Environmental concerns are at the top of global agendas, with businesses and governments under pressure to implement sustainable practices within the next decades. We are polluting our planet and need to push toward reducing carbon footprints, waste, and resource consumption. The urgent need to combat climate change and protect biodiversity will demand that companies increasingly align their strategies with environmental goals.

Climate Change: While *climate change* is a broad term, our impact on the world is increasingly evident and disruptive, pushing businesses, governments, and societies toward greater sustainability. Reducing emissions and transitioning to cleaner energy sources are critical steps in mitigating further damage.

Sustainability: As we operate in an economy that requires unlimited growth to sustain itself, a topic we will explore in Chapter 5, our limited resources become scarcer. Simultaneously, consumer preferences shift toward eco-friendly options. Sustainability is increasingly becoming a core part of some institutions' brands. This Megatrend includes everything around green energy, waste reduction, and sustainable sourcing to meet both regulatory and market demands.

Circular Economy: The circular trend promotes reducing waste and reusing resources through recycling, fixing and giving items a second life, and repurposing. The idea is to minimize environmental impact by designing longevity and resource-efficiency products.

Biodiversity Loss: The destruction of ecosystems and rapid loss of biodiversity pose serious risks to our planet's resilient yet fragile bio balance. Protecting biodiversity is essential for maintaining ecological balance, which underpins food security, clean air, and water.

SOCIAL AND DEMOGRAPHIC SHIFTS

Everywhere in the world, societies are undergoing profound changes accelerated by tech advances and the impact of a global economy; populations age, learning goes online, cities grow, new work cultures rise, health topics become more trending, and social movements reshape norms and expectations.

Demographic Change: As birth rates fall and life expectancy rises in developed countries, the aging population creates new challenges for healthcare, pensions, and labor markets. Industries must adapt to meet the growing demand for elderly care and address the shrinking workforce, and countries need to adjust their financial plans, pressured by the increasing demand for pensions.

Social Equality Movements: Thanks to the accelerated distribution of information through social media posts, activists advocating for socioeconomic, racial, and gender equality are gaining more awareness. This is making companies prioritize diversity and inclusion in their strategies, and social justice is becoming a moral requirement and a key factor in customer loyalty and brand reputation.

Urbanization: The global trend toward urbanization continues, with more than half of the world's population now looking for better job opportunities by living in cities. This change begs for an increase in smart city solutions, infrastructure development, and sustainable housing to accommodate growing urban populations.

Health and Wellness: Accelerated by alarming health trends, often related to the products we consume, people are placing more importance on mental and physical well-being, generating more buzz about health online and driving growth in the wellness industry. This trend affects everything from corporate wellness programs to consumer demand for healthier products and services.

Remote and Hybrid Work: The COVID-19 pandemic fast-tracked the adoption of remote and hybrid work models. This adoption has led to a fundamental shift in how businesses operate, particularly a cultural change where employees value the freedom to choose their place of work more than ever. These models offer flexibility but challenge companies to rethink office spaces, team dynamics, and communication. This tendency also fuels the gig economy's growth as more gig workers, freelancers, and contract workers join the market operating in a flexible, remote-first environment.

Reskilling and Lifelong Learning: In an era where rapid change renders parts of formal education obsolete by graduation, and Automation and AI disrupt traditional industries at an accelerating pace, professionals must continually update their skills to stay competitive. Lifelong learning is becoming essential, with both individuals and organizations investing in upskilling and reskilling initiatives.

GEOPOLITICAL AND ECONOMIC REALIGNMENT

The world’s political and economic orders fluctuate as countries attempt to predict the rapid change in the world with their political strategies. We are living through the times when power is shifting toward emerging economies and political movements like nationalism are gaining ground. Globalization, the dominant force shaping international relations, is being reevaluated as countries try to balance cooperation with protectionism. Digital consumerism and growing income inequality are also reshaping the global economic landscape, leading to new types of business models, political challenges, uncertainty, and further challenges in the environmental and social Megatrends.

Globalization vs. Deglobalization: Driven by the internet, globalization continues to shape international trade, but the rise of protectionism and nationalist policies is prompting countries to focus more on self-reliance. This shift is reshaping supply chains and global business strategies.

Income Inequality: Economic inequality is widening within and between countries, leading to political instability and social unrest. As wealth concentrates in the hands of a few, social media amplifies the trending struggles most people face, increasing pressure on governments and corporations to address wealth inequality through progressive policies and corporate social responsibility.

Shifts in Global Power: The rise of China, India, and other emerging economies is challenging the traditional dominance of Western powers, particularly the US Dollar as the global reserve currency. These shifts influence global trade, politics, and diplomacy, creating a more multipolar world order and increasing social uncertainty.

Nationalism and Populism: In our era, rising nationalist and populist movements are reshaping political landscapes in many countries, challenging global cooperation on issues like climate change, trade, and migration. These movements are fueled by rising tension and often prioritize local concerns over international collaboration.

Cyber Warfare: As technology is being applied to every corner of how everything operates, cyberattacks are increasingly being used as tools of geopolitical conflict, targeting critical infrastructure and influencing and misleading public opinion. This new digital battleground requires nations to invest heavily in both offensive and defensive capabilities in cyberspace.

Experience Economy: Consumers are shifting their spending from material goods to more memorable experiences, such as travel, events, and entertainment. This trend is transforming industries like hospitality, tourism, and retail, which are adapting to meet new expectations for experiential value. After the pandemic, this trend rebounded and now increasingly emphasizes personalization, safety, and integrating digital elements. In some cases, they even shape into hybrid or fully digital experiences.

Digital Consumerism: The rise of e-commerce, scroll-shopping, and digital and mobile payments is reshaping consumer behavior and business strategies. Companies must compete in today’s attention economy and innovate quickly to keep pace with evolving consumer preferences for seamless, engaging, personalized digital experiences.

Take a tiny break and make a mental picture. Go back a few pages and look at the Megatrends Visualization.

There are 25 of them, and imagine that any of these Megatrends, as well as any potential breakthrough, has the power to create an unexpected impact in our lives, work, or government. Looking at the visualization within a decade will feel like thinking back about the '90s today. So, consider them as a guide, even though you might not agree with each of them.

As an aspiring innovator, you have one job: you need to allow your curiosity to get you learning about these trends. Once you do, you need to connect the dots and combine! At least one or more of these Megatrends will heavily impact your industry and the innovation project you want to develop. Therefore, you must try to predict how the most relevant Megatrends for you will come together, then make a bet and commit to it.

After exploring the Megatrends, the next step is applying this knowledge. This requires an understanding of practical knowledge versus theoretical knowledge—because while trends offer insight, how you translate those insights into real-world action truly matters. When you learn about Megatrends, everything is theoretical, exposing you to hundreds or thousands of assumptions, but to materialize your ideas, you have to acquire practical, more actionable knowledge.

The way to gain practical knowledge is through the hard path of upskilling. You can read about magic, but that won't mean you can perform a trick. You can listen to a podcast to learn how to survive in the wild, but that won't guarantee that you will even be able to make a fire. You can watch a video tutorial on how to skate, but you won't be able to ride a skateboard. How do I know? Well, these are not some theoretical examples; these are hobbies that I have practiced at some point in my life. What the theory didn't tell me is that I would spend hundreds of hours just to master a single magic trick. What I didn't hear in the podcast is how my hands would bleed the first time I lit fire using wood sticks. What the skate video didn't show me is how hard and painful it is to fall on concrete in your 30s. These activities were orders of magnitude harder in real life than in the theory.

So, to move from knowledge to innovation, you can learn to convert your theories into actionable knowledge. In simple terms, learning is the ability to change to a new behavior under the same conditions. That means you will choose the same skateboard, the same ramp, and the same goal: to go down the ramp successfully. If you consume new knowledge, go to the skatepark to try the ramp again, only to do the same as always and fail while trying—you didn't learn. On the other hand, if your behavior changes as you move your center of mass a bit lower to get better balance, then you know that you truly learned—you changed your behavior even though the challenge had the same conditions. Behavior change usually leads to new results and, hopefully, better ones.

In the end, knowledge isn't just about accumulating facts—it's about turning those facts into action. Knowledge is the fuel, but your ability to apply it will drive your innovation forward. To succeed, you must remain open to learning, be humble enough to try and sharpen your skills, and stay determined to pursue growth.

4.3 Skills

Successfully going from a problem to an innovative, implemented idea has three prerequisites: adopt an innovator’s mindset to motivate yourself to take action, acquire industry-specific knowledge to conceptualize potential solutions, and develop skills to execute and materialize your ideas. I’ll introduce you to the skills that allowed me to build several projects, but keep in mind that innovation is highly competitive, with diverse, skilled groups working day and night to create new ideas, and the skills mentioned in this book may either work for you or not, depending on the circumstances.

The variables influencing your experience are limitless, turning seemingly impossible outcomes into achievable ones, and other times, you may fail at even the simplest tasks. One thing is certain: learning new skills and refining existing ones will always facilitate your journey in innovation. Along the way, failure is inevitable—and should be seen as a necessary part of the process.

In my 20s, I aimed to be a 'one-man army' and became obsessed with mastering dozens of skills, often going well beyond the basics. Today, I’m thankful my younger self prioritized the low-time preference of upskilling myself. This broad skill set helps me to quickly identify the hidden patterns behind Megatrends and how they are adopted, making it easier for me to take action. As you might have already experienced, education is a lifelong journey, so it’s never too late to learn new skills. The only real barrier is the mental battle: convincing yourself to commit enough time to learning solid skills that will help you tackle any challenge.

There are many ways to learn a new skill, but I prioritize three methods above all else: The first is hiring an expert and working alongside them. With enough time and exposure, you will learn the basics and where to put the most effort to make the biggest impact. Over repetition of thousands or tens of thousands of times, experts learn the most efficient ways of utilizing their talent; if you look closely and consistently ask why your hired expert chose a specific approach, you will soon uncover the fruits of their expertise.

The second method is to take on a project that challenges you to learn the necessary skills. Suppose you decide to become an entrepreneur, let alone start a company. In that case, whether you like it or not, this will push you to learn many skills: how to negotiate and do sales, marketing, product development, accounting, recruiting, strategy, legal, and many other skills, or risk going out of business. Alternatively, you can join another company or project in the field where you want to grow your expertise. However, changing the industry or project will not teach you new skills alone; it creates an opportunity to be curious every day and explore the wealth of untapped information available to you. You will still have to be self-disciplined and put in the needed effort to learn. If you have genuine motivation for the skill you want to level up, you can upskill by practicing new hobbies.

Suppose you support your upskilling with your hobbies—my third favorite method—you will most likely feel like you're progressing at lightning speed with little effort. However, chances are you're putting in more effort than you realize. That's because when we enjoy something, it feels like less effort is required, to the extent that I can go for days on end, barely eating or doing anything else, just immersed in learning and practicing a new hobby. These bursts of obsession are the only reason I learned so many skills in the past years.

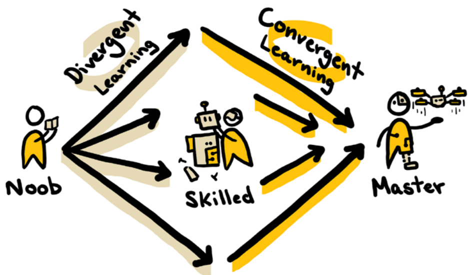
Today, I feel that I've embraced a mindset of continuous curiosity and learning. Along the way, I've explored various hobbies and skills—from practicing karate (earning a first dan blackbelt) to playing and developing video games, live streaming, visualizing complex ideas, making electronic music, performing stage magic, 3D modeling and printing, building virtual reality worlds and experiences, making videos, writing and sharing creative articles, tinkering with hardware, skateboarding, learning new meditation methods, experimenting with artificial intelligence, learning and teaching about finance and Bitcoin, creating art, and learning, embodying and discussing philosophy. Each of these hobbies has led me to unique, fun, and genuine experiences. Ask me in a year, and I'll likely have discovered something new. While I consider myself a terrible writer, tackling this book is helping me improve. Learning by doing has become a daily habit that I truly enjoy.

Playing video games has been the most consistent and my favorite of all my hobbies. Growing up, I learned English and developed a strong sense of morality through games like The Legend of Zelda. In my teens, I learned negotiation, trade, and avoiding scams while playing the online role-playing game RuneScape. Playing the right games can help you develop skills like memory, problem-solving, and spatial understanding. However, if you take the hobby further by creating your own mini-video game, you open the door to learning so much more while staying rooted in your passion. I learned storytelling, character creation, world-building, item design, music composition, sound design, programming, game testing and logging, and the fundamentals of game mechanics. And this was all in just a few weeks—learning fueled by passion is unmatched!

You can learn anything with passion, high goals, and hard work. Another example I'm proud of comes from playing the virtual reality game RecRoom. While the skills to defeat an army of cartoony robots might not seem work-related, it took a lot of effort. We aimed to claim the top spot and break the world record in an adventure called Jumbotron. We trained tirelessly, grinding the same levels for about half a year. We failed every single time, week after week, chasing that number-one spot on the leaderboard. Still, each failure taught us something new—teamwork, weapon accuracy, movement, or persistence—until we finally achieved the world record. We defended and held the top spot against tens of thousands of other players for several months.

In hindsight, it wasn't the goal we cherished most but the grind during those countless playing sessions. The journey was as if it came straight out of the movie *Ready Player One*, where learning and discovering a new virtual world with friends felt like the thrill of real life.

Mastering a skill unfolds in two phases: divergence and convergence. Divergence is the discovery phase, where you encounter new information from every direction. Whether you choose a book, an online course, or a tutorial video, you'll make progress, though measuring efficiency can be challenging. Every new piece of information feels like a truth, and you must navigate different assumptions to find the most effective way to develop each skill. Once you reach a skilled level, you can evaluate what truly works best for you—this marks the convergent phase. You become meticulous about how you allocate time to sharpen your skills. It shifts from doing more to doing less but with greater impact.

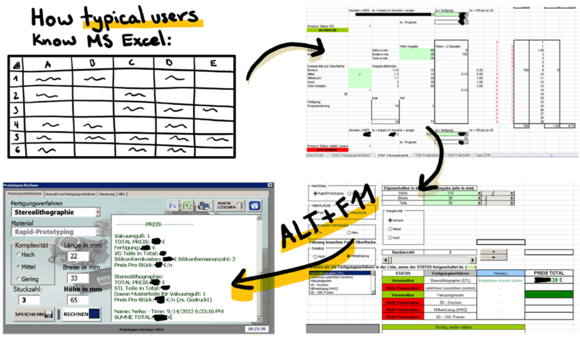


Imagine you want to practice martial arts to learn fighting techniques and master them. Initially, you'll want to learn every kick, punch, and move. Every action improves your fitness and builds muscle memory. In every fight, you throw a lot of kicks and punches; eventually, you'll know all the moves, and the focus shifts to efficiency, understanding the battle, positioning yourself in an advantageous spot, and managing your resources effectively. At that point, you focus on practicing specific moves, repeating them tens of thousands of times. Rather than scattering kicks and punches, you focus on perfecting the moves you're sure to land. Once you know when and where to land those signature moves of yours, that's when you have become the master.

The word *master* originates from the Latin *magister*, meaning *teacher*, highlighting why teaching often leads to mastery: the moment you start teaching others how to learn your skills, you will be forced to figure out what specific parts of your mastery deliver the highest impact. Structuring a lecture or tutorial forces you to reflect and pinpoint where the most value lies. In this, you reinforce them by practicing them even more, narrowing them even further, and becoming the best in your art. Teaching others is inherently a form of convergent learning.

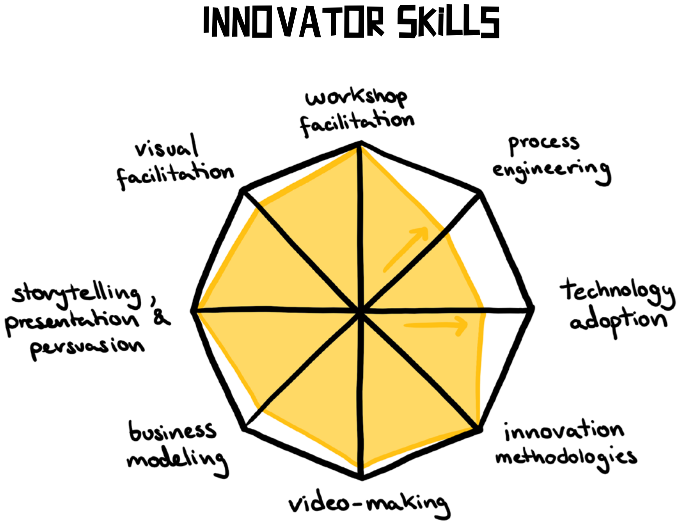
As your knowledge and skills grow—unlocking deeper layers of specialization—you'll go through multiple divergent and convergent learning cycles. A personal example of a cycle change comes from my time at a tier-1 automotive company in Germany. In 2012, I worked as a student in the sales and marketing department. I developed an interest in harnessing Microsoft Excel's full potential to tackle bigger problems. It began with mass formatting and cleaning data, followed by automating smart tables and crafting complex structures with lengthy formulas. However, one day, my boss assigned me a task I had never faced. My task was to reduce the prototyping cost calculation time from one week to the shortest possible timeframe while keeping estimated results within an acceptable range of the manually calculated values. I studied prototyping machines for two weeks, took detailed notes, and described each movement using math formulas.

I knew what to do, but I had a problem; I was repeatedly hitting Excel's technical limits. I sought help from the *Excel* Guru at our 6,500-employee company, a trusted colleague I had collaborated with for months on solving Excel challenges. He said, "Nelson, this is where my expertise ends. You'll need to explore Macros and Excel programming or find another approach." At the time, I saw myself as an "Excel Expert"—my colleagues often came to me for solutions—but I couldn't solve my own problem. With no AI available then, I scoured online forums for answers until I stumbled upon *Visual Basic for Applications* (VBA), which adds programmability to the *Microsoft Office* suite. The first time I pressed "ALT+F11" on my keyboard, *Excel* opened an entirely new interface that I had never seen before. For a second, I felt frustrated; after all, I was supposed to be an expert, but suddenly, the disbelief turned into curiosity, and curiosity turned into action. In short, after unlocking what felt like 99% of Excel's capabilities and programming new functions, I reduced the prototyping quoting process timeframe from one week to under two minutes. At last, I leave you with a quote I found on an old report, where my boss introduced the tool to the entire international sales team: "As you can see, it has turned out damn good. It needs to be put into operation ASAP!"



Discovery moments like these, when you begin a new upskilling cycle and re-enter divergent learning, can feel both daunting and humbling. If you've never had an experience like this, I encourage you to explore the software you know best and click every button and option—you'll likely discover something new.

As we delve deeper into innovation, it's time to consider some of the most impactful skills to enhance our portfolios. Karate may be useful for self-defense, but it won't exactly help you design the next groundbreaking product. Over the years, I've identified eight recurring skills that I consistently rely on—skills that can help you excel in launching or refining innovative ideas.



Workshop facilitation involves guiding a group from identifying a challenge to crafting a potential solution. Designing and facilitating workshops where new products and services are created is an essential skill for aspiring innovators. With well-designed workshops, companies can shrink the timeline from an unresolved challenge to a tested prototype—from months to mere weeks. If you want to innovate, you must be effective, and there is no more effective way of cooperating than with well-structured workshops. This isn't like the simple, three-step instructions you find on the back of a cereal box; I'm referring to the skill of designing a workshop structure from scratch and then executing it with the sole purpose of solving a specific challenge.

Mastering this skill in my twenties opened most of the valuable opportunities I have available today. The idea was simple: I launched my innovation agency, *WeSpark*, to build new skills and tackle diverse challenges across a wide range of companies and industries. Facilitating these workshops over the years kept me at the forefront of each company's most creative projects. All of this was in the hope that I would someday be inspired and knowledgeable enough to create new, unique, innovative products and services.

Process engineering involves determining the optimal sequence of events by analyzing how components function and interact. Similar to how a detective tries to put the puzzles of a crime together, here you try to understand how people, processes, and results come together. This skill reveals the structural backbone of any organization, and it's all about understanding the optimal step 1, step 2, step N. Understanding the sequence—what must happen first and what follows—brings clarity to even the most complex systems.

Analyzing processes was the first business skill I truly mastered. I love the mental challenge of joining a new company and trying to understand how it all works. With tools like the *spaghetti diagram* and *critical path analysis*, I began uncovering patterns in how companies operate, and this led me to unveil critical problems, from single points of failure to totally irrelevant positions or even a light case of corruption. Eventually, the patterns became too obvious and boring; all big companies, whether they had 5000 or 100,000 employees, followed the same patterns. After reaching this conclusion, I sought a more dynamic career path. Yet, this skill remains invaluable: identify a process bogged down by resistance, create a solution to accelerate it, and success will follow.

Technology adoption is discovering, learning, and utilizing the newest technological tools. Beyond *Google Workspace* and *Microsoft Office*, you'll discover countless tools for nearly every problem. Mastering digital or hardware tools makes you more versatile, efficient, and competitive.

Today, you can easily learn complex creative tools like *Blender*, a free, open-source 3D software, with help from AI agents and countless video tutorials online. You could master a new tool every month and become a tech geek in just a few years. Start with *NOSTR* social media, the Bitcoin Lightning network, or AI agents that let you create and deploy software from a single prompt. As you can see, technology has always been a topic close to my heart. Growing up tinkering with it made everything I build today so much easier.

Are you short on time to follow tech trends? Check out the YouTube channel *TechLinked* from *Linus Media Group*. In just 20 minutes a week, their three short videos keep you updated on the most prominent tech news. With today's online content and platforms, learning to program or develop any technical skill is easier than ever.

Innovation methodologies are like designing and running workshops but focus more on learning, designing, and selecting the right tools under any circumstances. This skill involves creating new creative processes every time you face unsolved challenges.

Before *WeSpark*, I worked at *Lufthansa Airlines*, where Carina, my first innovation mentor, introduced me to *Design Thinking* workshops. At the time, it was the most enjoyable work experience I'd ever had. Carina opened the world of innovation management to me. Soon, we traveled across Europe, designing and testing new methodologies for the European Union with incredibly creative people. This skill remains central to my toolbox, helping me design smarter, more effective solutions.

Video-making is straightforward: the skills to plan, record, and edit videos. Today, most social media algorithms favor short content videos over everything else. For now, video is the most rich content accessible to all internet users. Creating videos allows you to visualize and give life to your ideas and projects and easily share a consistent, structured, timed video message with your entire network.

Video-making was the first skill I picked up as a kid. Thanks to my mom, who used to be a reporter and later worked as a TV news director, I had access to video cameras in the middle of the '90s. I mainly recorded funny “fascinating” stories about superheroes and monsters, recording friends wearing costumes and acting out a scene. Other times, I would record time lapses of my toys in various scenes and then edit everything together using *Microsoft Movie Maker*. This is one of the most enjoyable hobby skills, and it helps me market my startups and projects. In the past, it even brought extra cash flow to my companies during costly development phases.

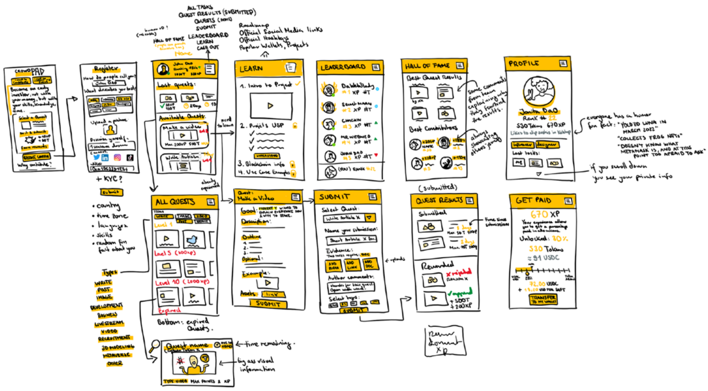
Business modeling is the art of designing sustainable and effective business models. Whether you're starting a business, non-profit, or government organization, you’ll need to understand how money flows, why the organization exists, and how it serves its target groups.

The *Business Model Canvas* is a popular tool I’ve used often but remember: every plan is just a starting point, no matter how solid it looks. Two common key business modeling lessons are focusing on money early and testing assumptions quickly. Over time, you’ll develop an instinct for spotting potential versus waste, signal versus noise.

Storytelling, presentation, and persuasion are essential skills for effectively communicating and spreading your ideas. Hooking your audience early and structuring your stories are powerful ways to stand out in today's information overload. After capturing your audience's attention, develop persuasion and negotiation skills to close deals and drive revenue.

As a teenager, my parents noticed that I often struggled to communicate clearly, and they sent me to multiple *Dale Carnegie* rhetoric bootcamps, as explained in Chapter 1. The *Carnegie* structures helped me craft stories that resonate and end with a strong "Call to Action"—a hallmark of any good presentation. When I launched my first company, *WeSpark*, I started following Chris Do's channel, *The Futur*, and learning negotiation and branding—resources I highly recommend.

Visual Facilitation simplifies complex ideas, systems, or processes through sketches that clarify their core mechanics. Visualizing concepts often reveals their strengths and flaws with striking clarity. Mastering the art of visualizing complex topics challenges you to fully understand the essence and mechanics of complex systems. It demands juggling countless variables, planning ahead, and prioritizing what to draw to organize your visualizations effectively.



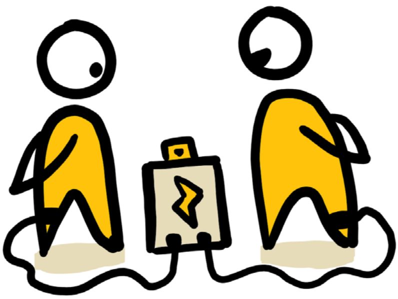
If I had to pick a single skill to keep, I would choose visual facilitation, my favorite skill by far. It sharpens my mind as I distill complex thoughts into simple visuals, adding immense value—especially during the initial stages of any project. It would be relatively easy for me to outsource every other skill to someone else. However, visual facilitation challenges my thinking the most and seamlessly integrates with any other skill to create value. It allows me to imagine and sketch full platforms before programming them, draw the entire storyboard of a video before filming it, design a unique innovation method before executing it, and, in general, imagine visually just about any version of the world that I want to build, and then create a plan on how to get there. Believe it or not, I struggle with words, which makes writing a book feel odd—but my obsessions drive me forward.

Visualization is always my starting point; as soon as I encounter a challenge, I mentally dissect and segment its core components. This book started with an urge to share my knowledge, and the first thing I did was visualize the front cover, then the back cover, and then the outline. Whenever I felt lost while writing, I would glance at the front cover to reconnect with the message I envisioned for you. I cannot explain most concepts with words, and I always had trouble with it as a kid, but if you just give me a single pen and paper, I'll visualize the complex mechanics of the world.

Getting started with visualization is a bit of a weird process; you often need to experience a gap in one area to develop strength in another. Just like how closing your eyes during a long period of time starts to magnify your other senses, you can force visualization, too. Try visualizing your idea, project, or company by explaining it solely through visuals—no words allowed. It's not about being an artist; it's about forcing yourself to just communicate with lines and shapes until it becomes a habit. You'll realize that many words you'd typically use to describe your vision are unnecessary and stray from its core essence. If this proves too hard, start by drawing your last vacation or daily routine, then gradually move to more complex topics. With practice, one line at a time, you'll master the art of visualization!

Fortunately for all of us, we don't have to pick a single skill; you can practice many of them, and definitely, you can balance all of the above. A good friend of mine and my only true "LinkedIn friend," Benjamin Dehant, inspires me often; Benjamin has always been sharing his progress in many artistic projects. If I share a new tool or concept with him, I'm certain he will dig into it, try it out, and share his thoughts, lessons, and tips on social media. In a world often marked by complacency, we should strive to emulate Benjamin's curiosity and drive.

Time is limited, and no one can master everything; at best, you'll refine a handful of skills in your lifetime. So, choose your skills wisely, aligning your passions with the tools necessary to bring your vision to life. Don't settle for merely doing your best—commit to doing whatever it takes, even if that means surpassing your current "best" and becoming the best version of yourself, mastering skills along the way. Do this, and whenever you put your hands on a project, you will slowly and then suddenly become a multi-skilled innovator!



5. GAME THEORY

Innovation is a demanding journey, fraught with uncertainties, unexpected hurdles, and even moments of peril. In a challenging and sometimes unfair world, what keeps you motivated when the path of innovation brings financial setbacks, burnout, or strained relationships? What drives you to persevere?

One key way to staying motivated lies in recognizing your incentives, as game theory shows us that every player, in business or life, acts based on anticipated rewards. From the beginning, it's crucial to identify what drives you—what makes the risks worth the venture. Without solid incentives, it’s easy to lose direction when challenges emerge, but with a clear reason to persevere, you can stay aligned with your original vision.

Patterns emerge when you listen to the stories of those who have created impactful projects on a global scale. Many faced life-altering struggles, moments where bankruptcy or despair seemed inevitable. Most shared an unshakable conviction that things would work out, coupled with perseverance and deep commitment to their cause.

As ventures grow and revenue rises, it’s tempting to believe financial resources alone can solve every challenge. Then, as companies expand and bring in new people and investors, the connection to the original purpose often weakens. Founders frequently become consumed by continuous growth demands, risking a gradual drift away from the core mission that initially inspired them. On the other hand, hard times usually remind them why they started, reconnecting founders with their core motivations amid uncertainty. However, as their projects grow larger and more profitable, opportunities to reconnect with their original purpose become rarer. This makes it essential to stay grounded, holding onto the values and goals that sparked your vision.

In the business world, there's a distinction between those deeply immersed in the challenges of innovation and those who might hold impressive titles but lack the mindset, knowledge, and skills of an innovator. Hands-on experience sets you apart—certain lessons come only from living through the grind and embracing uncertainty. Devoted innovators build expertise by repeatedly overcoming obstacles and solving complex problems. This real-world experience is invaluable and sets them apart, equipping them with insights and resilience that theoretical knowledge alone may not provide.

5.1 MISALIGNMENT

Your personal purpose and perspective may not always align with your employer’s goals. While companies value employees who align with their mission and vision, there can be challenges when personal goals don't fully match organizational priorities. In some cases, significant differences in direction can lead to difficult situations.

I've experienced situations where my commitment to innovation led to disagreements within the organizations I worked for. In one instance, expressing my critical thinking during my first weeks at work didn't align with a supervisor's expectations, leading to tension and the risk of being fired. Fortunately, others recognized my value in solving complex problems and supported me by transferring me to another project. In another case, I revisited a stalled digital transformation project that had been declared unsuccessful years prior. I took bold action, navigating bureaucracy to untangle the project and drive success within weeks. Unsurprisingly, I was warned for “breaking protocol and hierarchies”—even though I was simply doing my job as an innovation manager.

These experiences taught me that situations can get tricky when innovative ideas challenge established norms. Ultimately, they reinforced my decision to search for or build an environment where my creativity and commitment would be more appreciated. I always repeated to myself, “If I can’t find a good company, I will build my own company.”

The most skilled professionals seek challenges that test their abilities, driving them to mastery in their field. Having meaningful challenges motivates and excites them, making high-risk opportunities more appealing. This urge is why many innovators choose the entrepreneurial path, where they can fully apply their talents to positively impact the causes they care about.

Let's reconsider our understanding of entrepreneurship. I like to define it from the entrepreneur’s perspective as follows:

“*Entrepreneurship is trading your time, energy, and security for the unguaranteed chance to create something valuable in the world.*”

Entrepreneurs are often motivated by an irresistible reason or purpose to embark on new ventures. Their motivations range from personal aspirations like financial success, recognition, and sometimes even power to altruistic desires to make positive, meaningful contributions to society.

Innovation in big organizations can be tough because personal goals often don’t match company priorities. Most employees value financial stability, but innovation involves risks that can make managers and stakeholders uneasy. To navigate this, some companies establish separate entities or dedicated innovation departments to explore new ideas. These satellite structures aim to foster creativity while keeping risks low, though their effectiveness can vary. Unfortunately, in the companies I observed, these innovation efforts often don't lead to breakthroughs, but they at least show a step in the right direction. To have proper results, these structures should try to align the incentives and cultivate a culture that supports innovation by being bold and allowing failures to happen, allocating significant time for employees to learn and develop their ideas, and splitting rewards fairly with the idea creators. These elements are essential for achieving meaningful, balanced impact within larger organizations.

Sound incentives play a crucial role in the path to innovation. However, they also cause some of the most motivated innovators to leave their organizations, as working with colleagues who don't share the same passion, goals, and incentives becomes increasingly problematic. Problem-solvers often act on their own, exploring new areas and creating groundbreaking innovations, sometimes without recognition for years. By the time these ideas get noticed, traditional companies may struggle to keep up or even fail. Understanding and aligning incentives is key to nurturing this innovative spirit and keeping the best professionals.

5.2 WEAK INCENTIVES

It's common for companies to pursue innovation initiatives to meet shareholder expectations and sweeten their market position. Companies set budgets, hire innovation leaders, make big announcements, and publish press releases. However, it's vital to consider: Is pursuing innovation for its own sake truly valuable? What are the underlying incentives driving these efforts? Reflecting on these questions can help organizations ensure their innovation strategies are meaningful and effective.

Companies often want to invest in flashy “symbols of innovation,” like innovation labs or fancy titles for employees, to show they care about creativity. While these efforts can generate excitement and attract fresh talent to the companies, it's important to ensure that each effort goes beyond appearances.

The difference between “the illusion of innovation” and real innovation lies in the results: instead of marketing goals, companies set meaningful product feedback metrics as goals, where sensationalist speeches become solution-driven workshops, and where basic ideas transform into tangible outcomes. Companies can create environments where innovative ideas truly thrive by focusing on substance over style.

Projects are often under pressure to succeed because organizations want to share success stories with stakeholders and the public. Sometimes, average ideas can be presented and sold as groundbreaking through big partnerships, well-known brands, and heavy marketing. These ideas often go public, grow quickly, and then fail, leaving customers stuck with unsupported products. As a result, focusing too much on success stories frequently overshadows the valuable lessons we can learn from failures. To truly innovate, organizations must embrace both success and failure. This opens feedback channels, helping turn average ideas into crowd-tested products and services that are more likely to succeed. Companies can encourage experimentation and drive meaningful progress thanks to constructive public feedback by fostering a culture that values learning over public perception.

It's important to remember what we learned in Chapter 4.1, *Mindset*, and recognize the difference between low-time preference sustainable innovation and high-time preference initiatives prioritizing growth and fast profitability over long-term value. Companies that focus solely on growing quickly without genuinely delivering value risk facing legal and reputational problems. On the other hand, responsible innovation regularly considers environmental, economic, and societal factors, ensuring that progress contributes positively to humanity. Since the world's resources are limited, innovation that relies on using more resources can only go so far. Organizations and entrepreneurs must focus on strong, long-term incentives that create innovations for both our generation and the future.

A clear example of weak incentive structures is that some of the largest social media platforms prioritize user engagement and ad revenue over everything else. This behavior leads users to extended, often unhealthy, screen time and the development of cheap dopamine addiction. While these platforms can offer valuable services where friends can connect and artists can share their passions, there are significant concerns about how algorithms influence user behavior. Many users spend considerable time hooked on these platforms without receiving direct benefits, while companies monetize their attention and engagement.

We need to create a healthier relationship between us and technology. Constant exposure to quick dopamine hits, commonly available in today's society, harms our motivation, making it harder to take the tougher path of innovation where rewards require hard work, are delayed, and unguaranteed. In the end, weak incentives can drive institutions into financial trouble through laziness, irresponsibility, and inaction.

5.3 MONEY TROUBLES

One major problem with weakly incentivized businesses is that high-time preference ventures chasing quick profits often succeed with mediocre or dishonest ideas. This happens because society frequently celebrates charisma and rapid growth instead of valuing solid fundamentals. In 2023, several media outlets, such as *The Guardian*, reported that the *Forbes 30 under 30* entrepreneurs collectively raised 5.3 billion USD in venture funding. However, in the same year, some members of the list were involved in frauds and scams totaling over 18.5 billion USD. While this issue isn't unique to *Forbes*, it raises a question: Why do people support sensationalism instead of strong, value-driven, well-incentivized ideas?

The answer lies partly in how today's monetary system operates and its influence on our lives, time preferences, and decisions. We work hard for our money, but our governments have the power to print money out of thin air. When more money is added to the overall supply, its value decreases, making everything more expensive; and if everything becomes more expensive as money loses value, what incentives do we have to save?

Anyone who saves money in a bank will see its value decrease over time. So, what are we incentivized to do? Today, we are incentivized to spend money once it lands in our account and buy things we otherwise wouldn't. Many people take the risk optimistically and invest or gamble their savings, hoping to earn a return that restores or exceeds the original value. In part, our society celebrates sensationalism and quick wins because they align with the incentives created by a system that values rapid growth and quick gains over solid fundamentals.

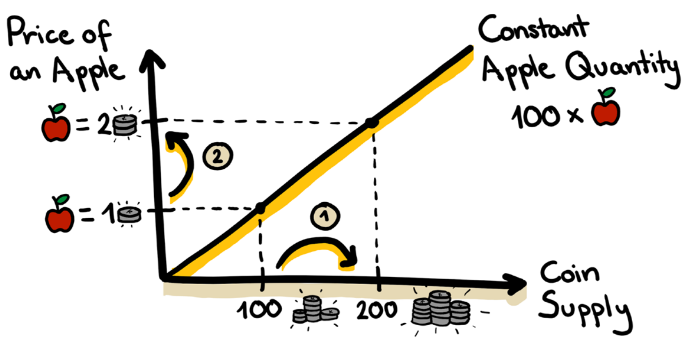
So, here's a short story to explain why money loses value when more is added to the supply: Imagine a fictional kingdom with 99 villagers and one king. Each villager trusts the king to make the best decisions for the kingdom. Our kingdom has 100 apples, and every villager and the king has one coin; collectively, 100 coins.

At the beginning of our story, the price for an apple is a single coin, so everyone can buy one. Let's suppose that times get hard, and disease spreads in the kingdom; the king gets nervous and tells the villagers that to deal with the situation, he will produce 100 coins to fight the sickness and stimulate the market. The coins are cheap to produce since they're made of nickel and require only the king's seal. Within a day, the coins are ready, and the king then distributes the coins to his nine closest allies and himself. The real issue is that no more apples were harvested, so there are still only 100 apples in the market. Now, we have 200 coins that can buy a maximum of 100 apples. To balance supply and demand, apple merchants raise the price to two coins per apple.

In conclusion:

1. When the money supplies doubles
2. The price of the apples doubles too

This might be fine if the new coins were distributed evenly, but in this story, the king and his nine allies received all 100 coins, and if they wanted, together, the 10 of them could buy over half of all the apples, leaving the other 90 with less than half an apple each.



This fictional story oversimplifies a much more complex system. Still, consider that printing more money without backing it with something hard to acquire, like gold, can easily inflate the supply and devalue the money itself, affecting everyone who works hard to earn it.

The general idea was to allow governments to stimulate the market and economy in times of need or when seeking innovation. However, the fundamental problem and the biggest flaw in every system designed by us is that we are human, and as humans, we make mistakes. Politicians can make mistakes, even with the best intentions. Unfortunately, not everyone has good intentions, and some politicians fall into corruption and make decisions that benefit themselves, the people closest to them, and the institutions that keep them in power. In all of this, we are the ones who lose because we labor in and endure this monetary system. Printing money is an easy, short-term solution that lets politicians get resources now while promising to pay later. This debt comes with interest, which adds even more to what must be paid back. Today, borrowing more money to pay off old debt is common—a terrible practice that speeds up inflation.

In simple terms, imagine that one of your friends asks you for 100 dollars and tells you that you will get the original 100 plus interest for lending the money for a year; this interest will be 10 dollars after the first year, so in theory, you will end up with 110 dollars by the end of it. However, before the year ends, your friend asks you to lend another 100 dollars and promises you 10 dollars more in interest payments. How would you feel if your friend asked you for more money before paying back the first debt? And how would you feel if it would happen more times? Without any backing besides words? Or with higher sums of money?

Over the past five years, global debt has surged dramatically, reaching $315 trillion by early 2024, up from $247 trillion in 2018. Debt grew much faster than the global economy, which only increased from $85 trillion to $107 trillion. This means we are creating debt at a ratio of roughly 3:1 compared to the value generated in the global economy. In other words, for every dollar of value created, three dollars of debt are added. This is extremely concerning, as it puts our long-term sustainability at risk. You should corroborate these numbers and look at the data from the *International Monetary Fund* (IMF), the *Institute of International Finance* (IIF), and the *World Bank Group*. Verifying yourself will allow you to properly digest the real significance and impact of the world's financial situation.

In terms of innovation, these weak incentives to make money fast contribute to more greed and, combined with irresponsible actions, caused the 2008 financial crisis. In the U.S., an estimated 5 million people lost their homes because of the crisis, and even though thousands of bankers and financial experts were involved in it, only one top-level banker went to jail for less than two years for it. Since then, the banks we trust have paid over 330 billion USD in fines and penalties for regulatory violations, misconduct, and compliance failures. At some point, we have to think whether we should trust these entities blindly.

If this wasn't enough, consider economic phenomena like the Cantillon Effect: in the book *Broken Money*, Lyn Alden argues that monetary policies can lead to wealth concentration. When new money enters the economy, it isn't distributed evenly—it often benefits those closest to its source. For example, large financial institutions typically receive loans at lower interest rates than regular people. Inflation reduces the value of money over time, allowing these institutions to repay their debts with money that is worth less than what they originally borrowed. In financial terms, this allows them to *short* the system they supposedly safeguard, profiting from its inefficiencies. As a result, wealth becomes increasingly concentrated in the hands of a few, widening the gap between rich and poor and worsening global inequality.

Why is all of this important for innovation? The answer is simple: The weak incentives we accept today, no thanks to the current monetary system, also have a direct effect on the type and quality of products, services, and platforms that we produce today. We must admit that growth and innovation are sometimes just illusions fueled by inflation and devalued money. If we fix the weak incentives, we can avoid money troubles; if we avoid money troubles, we avoid dishonest "innovation."

The only way to keep our current monetary system running is through unlimited growth—or the illusion of it. Slowing it down can kickstart a reaction chain that can cause the global economy to crash, just like a house of cards when any part of the foundation cards is removed. We can finally assume that "Wrong Incentives lead to wrong outcomes."

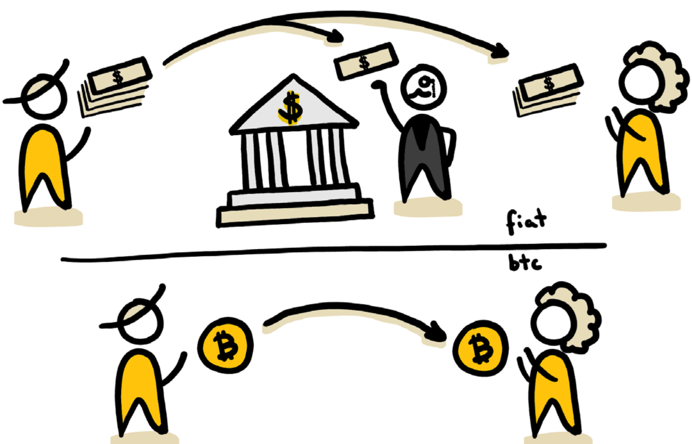
On a positive note, there are many ways to improve and align incentives for companies and employees. One approach is focusing on projects that genuinely add value to the world while being financially sustainable. Encouraging employees to try new things and learn from mistakes instead of punishing them for innovation-related failures can foster innovation. Allocating resources toward meaningful innovation, with an understanding that returns may take time, is crucial. Appropriately aligning incentives is a game changer for our world and can significantly impact our organizations, societies, and the future.

5.4 SOUND INCENTIVES

In society, innovators are the odd ones who don’t fit in or follow social norms. They’re often misunderstood but bring fresh ideas and challenge old ways of thinking. They may work independently, driven by a desire to change what needs change. Some chase big ideas that could disrupt systems and prefer to work quietly, avoiding outside distractions; they might use fake names to avoid being targeted by authoritarian governments that fear change in their systems.

These Mavericks think for themselves and for us, creating technology that protects freedom, technology that benefits us all. Like many entrepreneurs and innovators, they are all hands-on, putting in the grind, sacrificing petty pleasures, and instead following a vision. They saw a problem they couldn’t ignore, and even when others refused to see it, they chose to act for the greater good. It does not matter if there is no guarantee of succeeding; the opportunity alone is enough to try. When you have sound incentives and know that your work saves and improves lives, everything you do is aligned with the reward of living in a better world.

I’ve reviewed thousands of ideas, but few have truly caught my attention. I'm very fond of Bitcoin, a concept that created a peer-to-peer payment system that scaled from an idea to an international project and ultimately became a movement. Today, it is one of the biggest endeavors of humankind. It is a beautiful project that builds on the honorable idea that we don't need to trust any authority with our money if we can manage it ourselves. Bitcoin aims to fix problems like inflation, corruption, and unfair control of money systems. This isn't a book about Bitcoin; it's a book about innovation. However, Bitcoin is one golden example of global-reaching *Open Innovation*.



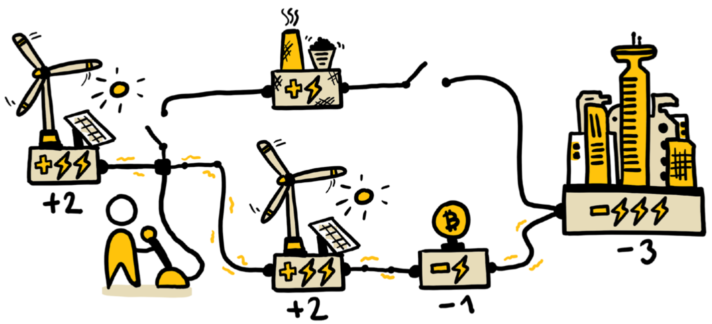
Simply put, Bitcoin's primary function is to allow one person to send money to another without relying on a third party, like a bank. This works because all transactions are recorded on a public list, and anyone can store a copy of every transaction ever made on their computer—eliminating the need to trust a bank to manage balances and payments. Bitcoin is essentially like a massive *Excel* or *Google Sheets* database that is shared transparently with the entire world and follows programmed rules.

Unlike traditional currencies, it is fully decentralized, meaning no single entity controls it. Instead, a global network of participants collectively maintains and secures the system. Anyone can participate by running software that keeps a copy of all transactions and uses computational power and energy to secure the network and validate new transactions. All participants have a chance to earn Bitcoin as a reward for contributing to the system. Additionally, Bitcoin is scarce by design, with a fixed maximum supply of 21 million BTC, making it fundamentally different from government-issued money, which can be printed indefinitely.

Assuming that you are an aspiring innovator, please try to have an open mind and forget everything you know about Bitcoin for a brief moment. If you think Bitcoiners are criminals or have heard that Bitcoin is used for buying illegal substances and that it harms the world, think about this instead: First, Bitcoiners are an extremely heterogeneous group of people, but at the core, we are human rights activists, developers, problem solvers, and volunteers. No one pays us to support Bitcoin; we do it because, against all the noise, we decided to put effort into researching and learning about it firsthand. I don’t believe there is a single person out there who dedicated

40 or more hours to understanding Bitcoin who doesn't love Bitcoin. I've spent over a thousand hours myself.

Second, using BTC for buying illegal substances is a bad idea; every single transaction is stored forever, and if you are doing anything illegal, you will leave transparent, indestructible evidence behind.



Third, Bitcoin doesn't destroy the world—it does the opposite. If you favor green energy, you will be happy to learn that Bitcoin allows for 100% renewable energy sources to thrive. In simple terms, due to the fluctuation of wind and solar energy, when there is less or more wind or sunlight, these sources can't reliably provide entire cities with energy alone. If they don't always produce sufficient energy that matches the city's demand, everything shuts down and goes into a blackout. Similarly, if you make too much energy that can't be consumed in real-time, the infrastructure can fry and cause a blackout. That's why it is common for renewable sources to be often accompanied by regulable energy sources like burning coal or diesel.

Suppose you only try to supply energy with renewable sources, and there is a surplus due to increased wind or sunlight. In that case, Bitcoin mining can use the extra energy from said renewable sources, making it useful instead of wasted. In return, the earned Bitcoins can be sold so that the energy company can operate at a profit without ever relying on dirty, harmful energy sources again. This is just one example, but there are other more complex examples of how mining Bitcoin allows for cleaner energy operations.

In my home country, El Salvador, Bitcoin is legal tender and part of the national treasury; BTC is officially recognized as money along with the US Dollar. Bhutan, a Buddhist country in the Himalayas famous for prioritizing national happiness, environmental conservation, and hydropower, has been silently mining and accumulating Bitcoin for years. Knowledgeable families in countries that experienced high levels of inflation, like Ukraine, Turkey, Argentina, Lebanon, and Venezuela, protect their savings by using Bitcoin instead of their national currencies. In the USA and Europe, pension funds and institutional asset managers have adopted BTC in their strategies. Just consider that during the first recorded BTC transactions, its price was below a single cent per coin, and recently, we have seen Bitcoin above $100,000 per coin. In short, Bitcoin is here to stay.

To be an innovator, you must be curious and ask yourself why hundreds of thousands of people are actively supporting Bitcoin by mining, running nodes, opening BTC-only companies, and running massive educational projects. It is all based on solid incentives and pure game theory. Bitcoin is fair, transparent money with fixed rules that don't favor anyone. Bitcoin can't be inflated beyond its maximum number of 21 million digital coins. The rules are digitally hard-coded, and it's practicably impossible to hack the entire decentralized network or to destroy it, and attempting this has no logical financial incentives.

Nonetheless, Bitcoin works not only because it has solid game theory, revolutionary technology, and sound incentives, but it also grows a lot because it embraces the principles of *Open Innovation*. All mechanics are based on transparency, proof of work through energy, and volunteer contributions, and it is open to everyone. I'm not mentioning any other cryptocurrencies, as they don't share the same sound incentives mentioned above.

In the unique case of BTC, its creator, *Satoshi Nakamoto*, who remains unknown to this day, showed us that we don't need central figures to lead the most impactful innovations in this world. Instead of seeking fame or wealth, Satoshi chose to stay anonymous. It has been more than a decade since Satoshi left the project in the good hands of the Bitcoin developers community. This protects Bitcoin from any attempt to take control over it; there is no central figure, no president, no board of directors, no company, no industry, nothing. It works because hundreds of thousands of people save a copy of the entire Bitcoin network in nodes across the world, and the only true way to stop it is to cut out electricity and the internet for the whole planet forever. Bitcoin teaches us that solid incentives and *Open Innovation* can create powerful and indestructible tools for freedom and mass collaboration.

The power of sound incentives isn’t limited to technology—it can also transform institutions and communities. One of my favorite examples is the *Gloria Kriete Foundation* (FGK), an NGO my company has proudly supported for years. *FGK* has a beautiful program called “Opportunities,” which extends and supports Salvadoran kids and teenagers with complementary advanced education, scholarships, and job training and placement. Every student makes an oath where they adopt sound incentives from the very beginning: "I pledge to bring better days for my community and my country." I can’t put into words how impactful this program is in my country, El Salvador. The thousands of students I have personally met are some of the best world citizens I know. The program helps them see and solve problems others ignore. If every institution out there would work with the integrity and efficiency that *FGK* has, the world would, without a doubt, be a better place.

In the technology and fintech industry, some startups claim to have created their own protocols to advance collaboration and acceptance. Still, these “protocols” are not open-source and are often privately patented, but if they are not public, they are just another operating system. To be a protocol, the developers need to have clear incentives and give the ownership of the patents to an institution such as the *IEEE* or similar. Once the technology has been reviewed and approved, it can become a public standard, a protocol that belongs to humankind.

Sound incentives make it possible to contribute to humanity and still be profitable. There are large research institutions that develop new technologies, patent them for a limited time, and distribute licenses for affordable prices before the technology is finally available to everyone for free after the expiration date. Another common way is by developing free, open-source projects that benefit from donations or doing customizable white labels and consulting projects as a revenue stream. This can be done while keeping a fully functional, all-features-included product free for everyone who doesn’t want or can’t afford to pay.

In today's connected world, if you want to create something big to help others, start with an idea, set clear goals and incentives, visualize it, and share it online. There are millions of talented and willing people to support you in creating your vision; all you need to do is share your dream and invite them to join you. If even one person joins you, you've already doubled your team.

The future is splitting into two paths, pulling apart as we speak, as millions of people actively work on building both sides. Which future do you want to help build?

- One is owned by companies that monetize us in their own interest.
- The other is built by us, for us, with complete transparency about the incentives behind our products, services, and platforms.

I can't choose for you. You need to honestly ask yourself which of these two futures you want to live in. One is easier to choose and more comfortable to live in, as we don't have to act or decide anything; the other is more sustainable and rewarding, but it comes at the cost and discomfort of acting ourselves. Choosing the second option is easier said than done.

We don't need more industries flooding our planet with useless products that pollute our oceans, more money custodians gambling with our savings, or platforms abusing our data and violating our privacy. We don't need to be trapped in endless scrolling, chasing cheap dopamine that damages our ability to think clearly and corrupts our brain's natural reward system.

We need more people who recognize the world's unfairness and are willing to sacrifice to build projects that benefit everyone.

You're not alone in this effort. There are communities like the *Open Source Everything* movement, where you can meet and work alongside thousands of motivated professionals to upgrade the world. It might take hard work at first, but as you make an impact and share your progress, you might have a chance of getting the support of some of the organizations and individuals that fund goodwill projects.

Groups like the *Human Rights Foundation*, which works to promote and protect human rights worldwide, and individuals such as *Jack Dorsey*, a tech entrepreneur and philanthropist best known as the co-founder and former CEO of *Twitter* (now called X) and the founder and CEO of *Block, Inc.* (formerly Square), have donated hundreds of millions to projects with noble causes.

In the end, bad incentives lead to bad results, while good incentives create prosperity. In a world where we rise against the misuse of tech, governance, resources, beliefs, control, and human lives, we must choose to be free from the temptations of weak incentives. We choose freedom with every action we take—by how we spend, where we focus, and what we create. The world is unfair, but we can make it fairer every day; we must stay strong, motivated, and committed, whether or not the odds are in our favor; if we do it long enough, the odds might just will.

If you feel that you have the right incentives motivating you, it's time to prepare mentally for the darkest moments we need to endure and conquer when attempting to innovate and support a good cause. I call the consequences of taking responsibility in our hands the *Unavoidables*.

6. THE UNAVOIDABLES

There's no such thing as a free lunch—everything comes at a cost.

If you decide to make the world better by taking a risky chance to innovate where it's needed most, be ready to face significant, unavoidable challenges.

I want to challenge your thinking here so you can make a clear, educated decision about what path to take. I don't want to stop you from trying, but I also don't want you to lose your footing—your finances or peace of mind.

There are many ways to innovate. You can be an entrepreneur, which comes with big rewards but also considerable risks. Or you can choose safer paths: you can become an intrapreneur, someone who creates a new venture within an established company where you might be limited to what you can do but without facing sizeable risks. Or you could also work for an innovative company that shares your goals and beliefs. These are still great and honorable ways to make a difference.

However, if you choose the entrepreneurial journey, to lead, to aim for what no one has done before, know that you'll have to make sacrifices.

Unless you're lucky enough to have endless resources and wealth, you'll need to accept three unavoidable challenges: *Uncertainty*, *Getting Stuck*, and *Failure*. Even if you are in a fortunate situation where you have lots of resources at your disposal, these unavoidable events will affect you one way or another at a scale relative to the size of your project.

6.1 Uncertainty

Uncertainty can feel unbearable.

The stress and anxiety it causes can seriously impact your health and slow your progress. This is an important topic that shouldn't be overlooked. Not knowing when things will get better can eat you up inside. Thankfully, there are ways to handle uncertainty: focus on what you can control and let go of what you can't.

As an entrepreneur myself, I know only times of trouble. In 2019, I started my first company, *WeSpark*, on a whim—with no savings, no clear plan, and no customers. As we learned in Chapter 2, It took me six months to learn the basics of marketing and sales before I finally landed my first customers. Once the first customer signed, I rapidly started getting more customers, but just as the outlook began to look positive, the COVID-19 crisis started. Just like the pandemic, events such as the invasion and war in Ukraine and talks of a looming recession in 2024 have hurt the projects I'm working on. In short, all I know as an entrepreneur is hard times.

For an entrepreneur, certainty is like standing on a mountain. One moment, you can see everything clearly. The next, clouds roll in, and you can barely see what's ahead. It's a never-ending cycle of times of uncertainty and times of clarity.

One of my hardest days was when I didn't know how I'd pay rent the next week and feared losing my home. After taking a shower that night, the pressure overwhelmed me, and I crumpled to the floor, wet and defeated. For a moment, I cried.

Fear took over, and I collapsed. While on the ground, I remembered a lesson from a *Dale Carnegie* seminar I had as a teenager. I thought: "What is the worst thing that could happen to me now? Death? Certainly not! Bankruptcy? Perhaps. But would that be the end of the world? Again, no! However, is it probable? Only if I wouldn't act!" After a minute, I got up, got dressed, grabbed a small notebook, and wrote down every step I'd take before even thinking of quitting.

I then listed 19 people—friends, customers, and former coworkers—who might be able to help. I knew that at least one of them would be able to support me and that the worst-case scenario would only happen if I didn't take action. That dark moment led to reflection; reflection turned into a plan, and the plan became action that pulled me out of uncertainty.

Dale Carnegie once said, "Today is the tomorrow you worried about yesterday." This statement introduces the idea that our fears and anxieties about the future often become less overwhelming when that future becomes the present. Dale knew that worrying is unproductive because it takes away from our ability to enjoy and engage with the present moment.

The time to act is now. A classic mistake is waiting for the “perfect” moment to start. However, there are two commonly agreed truths between the entrepreneurs in my network: the first is that there is never a perfect moment. There will always be an excuse trying to hold you back, and there will always be a sense of discomfort in taking action. The second is that it is not in your long-term interest to grow a lot during easy, prosperous times without solving hard problems because once the hard times come—and they will—your project could plummet faster than it grew if you didn’t shape your crisis-solving skills. Instead, if you become disciplined and resilient during tough times, you’ll know how to succeed no matter what comes your way.

It requires courage to follow the difficult entrepreneurial journey, but if you choose to be the vanguard and pursue unexplored innovations, then consider that the challenge will be magnified in terms of difficulty. Fortunately, we’ve learned about tools and skills that can help us. Tools and abilities like visualizing, learning, prototyping, collecting feedback, and reflecting will all help us take the next step to battle uncertainty. Just alone, the simple combination of creating a cheap prototype and getting constructive feedback from a customer can take us out of uncertainty.

One lesson from my journey is that living in total uncertainty is exhausting. You will want to cover your basic needs first—food, shelter, and financial stability—so you can focus your energy on innovation without the constant stress of covering essential needs. Sometimes, having little familiar things that don't change or disrupt your work can greatly help. You can call me crazy, but I find calm in listening to the same songs in the same order repeatedly. Even while writing this book, I listened to hundreds of hours of my *Mega concentration* playlist. Whenever I need to do something hard or in the middle of uncertainty, I can enjoy the soothing, predictable songs and instantly work on just about anything. If you are curious, I'll add the playlist to the *Resources and Links* section at the end of the book.

As we learned in Chapter 2, *Unmeasurable Acceleration*, the world is changing fast; because of this, so much is uncertain; we can never know anything for sure. We must embrace the unknown. The challenge is that those close to us—friends and family—may sense our sacrifices but often won't understand our vision until it's realized. With their best intentions, they will suggest we leave our projects and get our conventional jobs back. It's hard enough to innovate against the odds, yet others will try to discourage us along the way. While they sense our sacrifices and pain, they might never be able to understand our vision till after we realize it. It's easy to react with arrogance, but staying humble will serve you better: listen to your family and friends and suggest with a calm, slow voice that if things get nasty in the future, you can always get your old job back. This will neutralize most situations without escalating them.

In these uncertain times, pursuing innovation will attract criticism from those around you. Don’t let people tell you what you should or shouldn’t do, especially if they don’t know what you know. If these critics aren't family, friends, partners, or investors, you can safely ignore their opinions. Remember that they haven’t committed to fixing the problems you want to solve, and they don’t share your incentives. Focus on your work and filter out the noise while staying alert to potential signals. In recent years, I learned that we should not let external opinions become an added source of uncertainty.

To navigate uncertainty, I adopted certain behaviors, such as running while listening to audiobooks or music when stress levels rise. I also started walking in the forest, doing micro-meditations and breathing sessions throughout the day to dissolve any anxiety. As social beings driven by emotion rather than cold logic, we best embrace uncertainty through interaction with others. Innovation is easier when you do it together with other like-minded and similar-incentivized people. Being a solo innovator can feel like madness, and working with other passionate partners can feel more encouraging. However, working with the wrong partners is, in almost every case, more harmful than working alone; therefore, you should always choose people who align with your values. Remind yourself from time to time that the closest people will always influence who you are, positively or negatively.

When you have good people around you, life is more enjoyable. Though it may not seem relevant, this truly relates to the topic of innovation. In your journey of creating new things, you will face challenges that might put your sanity to the test. Solid, genuine friendships will help you keep calm in moments of turbulence. True friendship is forged in moments of vulnerability, supporting each other through difficult times. Just like happiness is better when you share it with someone else, sharing thoughts of uncertainty has a similar positive effect, too.

A special characteristic of solid friendships is that they become a natural group where wisdom and knowledge are shared. You won't need to try to catch up with every news when you have good friends learning and sharing. If your colleagues and friends know you and associate you with particular topics, be sure that they will share any major relevant news, trends, and breakthroughs they come across with you. For this to happen, you want to surround yourself with the best friends possible and do everything to be the best friend possible for them, too. Protect them like family—because they are family, one that you choose, and be sure that they will protect you from dishonesty, madness, or making bad calls. You have to curate the people closest to you and nurture those friendships.

Dealing with uncertainty is just a matter of courage, and it’s easier to be courageous when we have great friends to ride with toward the uncertainty beyond the horizon.

6.2 Getting Stuck

Getting stuck means sustained suffering.

While we're trapped by a problem, unfinished idea, or unresolved situation, life will perpetually bring back the pain. Just as droplets of water can erode stone over time, being stuck in a recurring, uncomfortable state inflicts lasting mental and emotional damage.

During a short retreat with my closest friends in Thailand, we had the opportunity to amplify our wisdom thanks to a conversation with Kiki, a Theravada Buddhist monk. He explained that in the ups and downs of life, it is natural to go through difficult situations and suffer. His simple yet profound advice for a better life was to understand the right amount of suffering, noting that we often relive the pain of certain situations, dwelling on them and draining our energy.

Suppose we apply Kiki's wisdom to our business. Sometimes, we ignore the bigger, harder tasks, and in doing so, these unsolved problems continue to impact our projects negatively in the background. We often know what to do to take our ventures forward, yet we focus on minor achievable activities—quick wins like answering emails—while ignoring the problems that must be addressed. In one of my projects, we built a platform that worked well, but some technical bugs needed attention. Naturally, designing and adding new features is more fun and pleasant than fixing bugs or improving a lengthy process, but it wasn't until the platform grew that we noticed the impact of not fixing the bugs early. As more users started to join the platform, my team and I noticed the number of support tickets increasing, and we solved each problem manually–which was manageable. Once thousands of users joined daily, the tiny issues we hadn't fixed months earlier became more significant, and the amount of effort needed to address each user became unmanageable. Today, I know that it was worth stopping the work on new features and doing the tedious work of fixing the issues first. So, the next time you face a challenge, please ask yourself if you want to commit to resolving it once and for all or choose to ignore it and accept the consequences.

On your innovation journey, focus your energy on your highest priorities. That means saying *no* to most things so that you can say *yes* to the things that you need to do. For instance, over the past five years, I've kept my calendar largely free from recurring meetings, allowing me to focus on what truly matters day to day and week to week. I rarely respond to emails or messages on LinkedIn; when I do, it's brief and reserved for those who truly deserve my attention. Additionally, I changed my number recently and will do the same again in the next months, so the only people who know where to call me are my family, closest friends, and customers. When you allow just about anyone to distract or disturb you, you will lose valuable time that you could have spent solving the problem.

Once you start to guard your time from everything and everyone else, you will quickly find more time to dedicate to everything that matters: the people closest to you, your health, and your project. From time to time, some people might go through filters and find a way to catch your attention. Usually, in my case, I tend to properly dedicate my time to the ones who truly have something to share; this is how new partnerships and ventures start. It's not about ignoring everyone; that would be misguided. Instead, guard your time against generic messages and engage with those who genuinely want to connect.

Furthermore, if you notice you have enough free time to tackle your pressing, recurring problem but still feel stuck, it's a sign you shouldn't free up more time—you need to get busy! If you're honest with yourself, you likely know the solution to your problem. Maybe it's making more calls or finally addressing that delayed accounting task. So, it's not that you are ignorant of the solution; it's just that you haven't committed to solving it.

If you're unsure of your next steps, take your most pressing problem and ask yourself, "How can I make this problem ten thousand times worse?" It might seem counterintuitive, but we often think better in terms of problems than solutions. Whatever the worst ways to aggravate your problem are, take them and do the opposite—this is most likely the solution.

If you do the above and are still stuck, you will have to resort to more conventional innovation methods. One of the most practical ones is to pick a problem, idea, product, service, organigram, or whatever you need and systematically see it from a different perspective. The most popular methodology for small tasks requiring some imagination is called *SCAMPER*, popularized in the '70s by Bob Eberle. He describes a method where you take each letter and follow the call to action: *Substitute*, *Combine*, *Adapt*, *Modify*, *Put to another use*, *Eliminate*, and *Reverse* —just like we learned above.

One innovative example comes from *Heatbit*, where they *substituted* the heating coils from the electrical heater for 5nm silicon chips that warm up by processing and solving math problems—mining Bitcoin. This creates a new class of products, such as heaters that pay the users back with BTC, all while using the same amount of energy as your normal electrical heater.

Other methods don't rely on creativity and can help you clearly see what needs to be done to unstuck yourself or your project. The *Lightning Decision Jam*, designed by Jonathan Courtney, is the easiest to learn and apply under almost any circumstance—as long as you have a team. This simple yet powerful process involves collecting information, choosing which problems matter, creating direct solutions, and committing to action.

If your challenge is substantial and can't be solved easily, maybe because it requires proper investment or coordination of multiple teams and experts, then the most recommended method could be the *Design Sprint*. Jake Knapp popularized this framework in his book *SPRINT: How to solve big problems and test new ideas in just five days*. It guides you through some steps where you strategize, visualize, storyboard, prototype—with extra support from designers or developers—and test your idea in just a matter of days or weeks. This is a powerful alternative to the *Design Thinking* process many companies use, as it is fully structured, and every step of the method is defined.

As an aspiring innovator, it will be beneficial to familiarize yourself with enough innovation and management tools. As you gain experience, you can improve and learn to design customizable and unique methodologies. Still, whether you know all the tools or not, sometimes—especially in the case of the *Design Sprint*—it's beneficial to hire a neutral external facilitator, allowing you to focus your critical thinking without the distractions of leading the process.

Some of these methods will probably help you get unstuck, so learn and keep them in mind or come back to this book because, sooner or later, getting stuck will be unavoidable.

At some point, you may feel stuck despite your best efforts to solve the problem. Remember that it is normal for the innovation process to test your patience and commitment. I'm not suggesting you take a vacation to get unstuck, but sometimes, it helps to step back from the problem.

One of the oldest and most effective methods for getting unstuck is already in our DNA. Over two thousand years ago, in ancient Greece, Aristoteles and his students documented the process of teaching and discussing ideas by walking around the Lyceum. Today, this approach is known as *Peripatetic Learning*, from the Greek word *peripatetikos*, meaning *to walk about*. I embraced this method after learning about it while helping design and test innovation methods for a European Union project. During a full-day walk in *Dartmoor National Park*, we used the landscape as a metaphor, reflecting on challenges as we walked uphill, staying quiet at times or choosing easier paths to discuss ideas with one another. Walking is an empowering activity you can do almost anywhere, regardless of the weather. During the most difficult times of my entrepreneurial journey so far, I walked every day for one hour around midnight. The absence of people, noises, and distractions always allowed my mind to focus all the energy on the problem at hand. Walking helps you think and persevere.

Other activities that can help include meditating and breaking routines. Meditation can have similar effects as walking, and combining the two is possible. On the other hand, breaking routines will expose you to chances of getting new, fresh inputs that can get you unstuck. I personally prefer to stick to the more active methods that put the problem under the magnifying glass, as some indirect methods can help you feel temporarily better but might only give you the illusion of progress. To know if you're truly progressing, just look back; everything tends to make sense in retrospect once you've had time to process it—perhaps through meditation, journaling, or reflection. What’s difficult is focusing on the present, as just doing something and filling our schedules with lots of meetings and tasks can make us feel like we are progressing, even though we might just be delaying that one critical, tedious thing we need to do.

In my network of entrepreneurs, I noticed that the ones who focus a significant amount of their energy and time on their projects are the ones who succeed. Here, focus means eliminating all distractions that don’t add the most value to reaching your goals. More often than not, the sacrifice and discomfort of removing all distractions are imperative for innovation. However, we are all different, and the methods that work for me or my entrepreneur friends might not work for you and your situation.

When I have something important to do, I wake up and go straight to my computer to finish the job. Using my *Mega concentration* playlist, I can go into a hyper-focused mode every single day if I need to. This allowed me to outwork others at the start of my career and gave me sufficient time to learn topics that would teach me even more. Repeatedly, I accomplished in hours what others took weeks to achieve.

While I don't have any special tricks to tell you how to be hyper-focused, I can tell you for certain that anyone can do the same. How do I know that? Well, because I'm sure that I'm not special in any way. What I do are the things I choose not to do, and you could easily make the same choices. When I want to focus, I start by putting my phone away and eliminating all distractions. Additionally, I strive to avoid drugs—especially those that affect my thinking, focus, or energy—so that means no caffeine (coffee), nicotine, alcohol, or sugar. Sweet cravings are the hardest to resist, as sugar is almost everywhere, and I sometimes catch myself slipping back into that addiction. For more on this topic, check the book's official website in the *Resources and Links* section.

If you can’t resist those temptations, at least try to avoid the dopamine hit from social media today; remember that innovators prioritize low-time preference over high-time preference. Believe me or not, I avoid using social media unless it is specifically for work.

A good practice is to uninstall the apps from your phone so that you can access them from the computer every time you have the urge to use them. The extra barrier and tiny discomfort of not being accessible from your phone are enough to stop you from using most social media. If your work depends on it, you can still use the platform from your computer.

As a tiny example, the last app I uninstalled from my phone, which was slowly damaging my productivity and happiness, was *X* (formerly *Twitter*). I had installed it for work but caught myself one too many times opening the app out of instinct. I eventually made the hard choice to delete it for good and only to access it through my computer.

On the first day, I started breaking the unhealthy habit of “checking out the news” for hours or allowing the app to steal my attention. Basically, whenever I had to do something tedious or intellectually challenging, my brain would, by default, command me to reach for my phone and start scrolling. Believe it or not, just a couple of days after I deleted *X* from my phone, I was confronted with plenty of recovered extra time and decided to do something valuable—this was the trigger that got me writing this book.

If you recover time, don't waste it! People often say that the best way to get rid of an addiction is to fall into another one. If it's not scrolling social media, then it's binge-watching shows, and if not the shows, maybe shopping online. I can't think of a better way of staying stuck. Build the habit of taking ten seconds before starting the next episode or opening a social media app to ask yourself if there's anything more worthwhile to do in your life. This simple and powerful question gets me out of the couch every single time.

While it's inevitable to procrastinate occasionally, there are two forms of laziness: inactive laziness, where you don't take any steps toward your goals. You choose the easiest, smallest rewards daily, remaining stuck as long as this behavior persists. The second is smart laziness, which involves temporarily stepping away from the problem. This means filling your time with learning new skills or advancing other topics while acknowledging and documenting any ideas or solutions that arise, then returning to your original challenge. Here, you continue to gather information regardless of what you do. Once you have the input to get unstuck, block out time to tackle the original issue you've been struggling with.

Getting unstuck involves focusing your energy on what matters and protecting your time from distractions that don't align with your goals. While there are innovation methodologies that can help you figure out complex challenges, please do not assume that they will work each time. Sometimes, your problems require you to test things out, diagnose what is going on, and apply what you learned. Remember, the transition from being stuck to unstuck can be a moment of truth—an opportunity disguised as a challenge.

If you find pleasure in hustling towards achieving your overall goals, even little by little, then I'm sure you will never get stuck for too long. In conclusion, it's about perseverance and sustained relevant activity toward solving a big problem; this continuous progress makes the innovation journey enjoyable.

6.3 FAILURE

Forward Failure is progress.

Of all the bad things we can imagine when embarking on our innovation project, failure is the gravest and the one that comes to mind first. Experienced entrepreneurs will tell you that failure is unavoidable; only companies that don't exist make no mistakes.

Talking openly about your failures is good; you need to own them as they are part of your history and shape your character today. The best group of people to talk about failure are other entrepreneurs, as they will understand your struggles and may offer their advice or even help directly address your problems. Moreover, knowing that there are more "crazy people" out there will help you remember that you are sane.

If talking with other entrepreneurs proves difficult, I recommend journaling your personal and business experiences—what's happening, why you think it's happening, and how to resolve the situation. Writing down your thoughts can help you spot flaws in your processes and reduce overthinking. Documenting your challenges and lessons allows you to reflect on your progress and fully absorb what you've learned. You can do this privately in a journal or publicly through articles. In fact, this book itself is an example of writing to process recent failures. If there's one thing I've collected the most, it's lessons—and stories—of failure. When I was five years old, my parents put me into Karate lessons, and one of the most vivid memories I have is my Sensei asking: "What do you do when you fall a thousand times?" And I always replied: "I'll stand and rise a thousand times!"

Today, I realize that this early discipline and repeating such statements hundreds of times created a mental manifesto that predicts how I'll act in front of any challenge. I have lost all my savings trying to raise innovative projects three times, but as I see it, I just paid a premium to adopt new wisdom and experience. When you attempt to innovate through entrepreneurship, you need to be aware that the rate at which you need to learn to survive in the market will be more challenging and rewarding than anything else.

One curious entrepreneurial phenomenon I experienced is that sometimes, you can fail in the middle of growth. In one of my latest projects, we created a digital platform that allows companies to orchestrate massive marketing campaigns with all their customers. We grew the platform from 100 users to over 100,000 in six months—a moderately successful speed for a new startup. However, as we grew, the minor problems started to magnify with the increasing volume of new users. We spent three hefty months pulling 100-120-hour work weeks under enormous pressure of total operational collapse. In those months, a single day without critical or massive failures would be considered a good day. Under this pressure, the first misalignments of incentives between the team started to show wear and tear. At the same time, the platform's weaknesses in its game theory started to present themselves, and even though the technical mechanics were solid to serve thousands, the weaker fundamentals became as vulnerable as Achille's heel. Of all the possible ways of failure, failing while growing and being wiped out of all your savings are the two most brutal variants I had to endure.

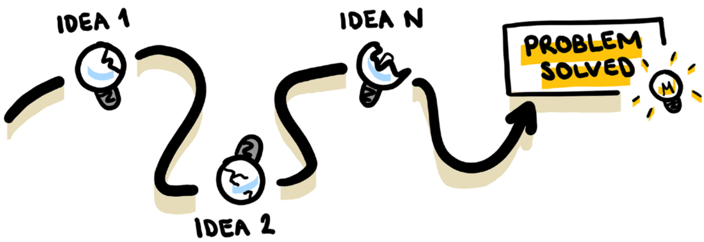
On other occasions, I have created products or services that have worked since the beginning. They were suitable for a small niche market yet still innovative, profitable, and relatively simple to maintain. My direct advice is that if you ever encounter these types of silent success, just stick with it. If you want to pursue something else, do it, but entrust your already-working innovation to someone who can continue the business for you. This last piece of advice is one that I had to learn the hard way myself, as I often jumped from one project to another. If I had dedicated more time to these niche businesses, I could have created a steady flow of cash to empower my newer projects financially.

The days after you become aware of your failures will be the hardest, but remember, you are successful as long as you believe it yourself. Only you define your success—it could mean generating wealth, enjoying free time, showcasing your art, sharing positivity, doing charity, exploring the world, or anything you dream about.

To grow, you must embrace failure as an unavoidable part of the journey. The ultimate and unbeatable test for any innovator is to try things out and either validate or kill any assumptions you have. Putting substantial efforts and resources into validating your assumptions can take a toll when they don’t turn out in your favor, but that’s the trade-off you accept on the path of innovation.

Only by accepting and correcting mistakes will you find the way forward. As my previous partner in business, Stan, told me once, the death sentence of any startup is when you start lying to yourself and blindly believing in your assumptions. Seeking constant feedback is crucial, and being brutally honest when receiving it is imperative. The difference between failure and definitive failure—game over—is your ability to keep participating in the journey.

Your drive becomes one of your primary resources; the initial unsolved problem that triggered you to start it all is your main source of motivation. Only if you are truly motivated by what you do will you find the strength to rise a thousand times and ultimately overcome failure. As long as your problem is unsolved, you will find yourself repeating the process of trying to solve it over and over again. This doesn't mean that you will be doing the same thing repeatedly; it means that you will try to solve the same problem differently each time, and every new time that you try, you will know how not to solve it based on your earlier failures and learnings.



You don't want to get attached to your idea. You wish to fall in love with solving the problem! Because if you fail to implement one idea, and that's everything you have, the moment it fails—and if it is your first, it most likely will—you will have nothing to continue for. Instead, if you get obsessed with solving a problem, if the first idea doesn't work, you move to the second idea, the third, and the hundredth; as long as the problem is unsolved, you will have the motivation to continue. Naturally, you must create abundant ideas and do whatever it takes to make them work before moving to the next. This is the way of the innovator.

With every failure, you get closer to your purpose. In the case of the platform I mentioned, the purpose remains to connect customers with their favorite brands in a way that allows them to contribute directly to the companies, all while getting rewards back. The concept is called Decentralized Engagement, and after the last failure, I'm convinced the platform needs to have a different application in other industries for it to shine. Still, some main concepts must be reevaluated to create stronger incentives and improved game theory before attempting to make it work again. With this approach, it's easy to recognize that I don't start from zero again. With my previous team, we ventured into uncharted territory, continually exploring new paths. No one can tell us what works and what doesn't—they don't have experience—so we need to figure it out ourselves. Every assumption needs to be tested, or it just remains an unknown.

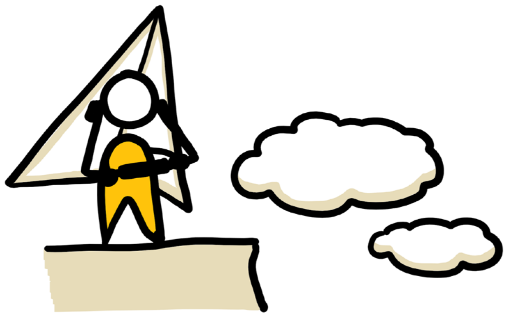
With this in mind, your second primary resource is the ability to participate and try to innovate again. You can lose your money, but you can't lose your knowledge, wisdom, all the learnings, the processes, the experience, and resilience. However, if you have weak incentives, as covered in Chapter 5, you can lose your mind, friends, relationship, reputation, or even your freedom—if you commit fraud and land in jail. In contrast, money can be re-earned, a team can come back together, and a new company can be built.

One way to maintain a strong momentum is by testing assumptions early, allowing for early failures with minimal resource loss. This means you will risk and lose fewer resources and be able to test assumptions with a higher frequency, failing in small steps, but even though you are getting smarter each time, at some point, you will suffer from a major loss, and it is this moment that you still need to prepare for.

As a teenager who loved quads and motorcycles, my biggest role model was Travis Pastrana, an American motorsports and stunts professional most famous for the first double backflip on a motorbike. Travis's story of courage, perseverance, and love for extreme moments captivated me. In his documentary *199 Lives*, he describes his stunt career as "calculating risk for a living." Despite the planning, extreme sports and stunts inherently come with high risks, and Pastrana has endured countless injuries. As he once remarked in an interview, "I don't remember most of the injuries—there have been too many." However, at the age of 14, Travis had a major accident that had him in a wheelchair for months before recovering and continuing to beat more records and win more competitions.

Travis's story taught me that sometimes we might think we failed too big and that our career might end. Still, by embracing and going through the pain and projecting ourselves into a future where we stand up again, we will continue to do what we love, and our intentions will manifest.

Remember that failing is an unavoidable learning process and an imperative part of progress. As you innovate, you will make both small and significant mistakes; however, if you commit to projects that genuinely motivate you and maintain sound incentives, you'll always find the strength to rise again.



7. COMMIT OR DO NOTHING

One day, just after you commit to innovation, the next moment of truth will present itself. Just like crossing a chasm, you get close to the edge to have a glance—it's deep. You take several steps back, look straight, and start accelerating. As your body builds momentum, you get closer to the edge, and there's no turning back—no stopping. The only way is to jump forward as far as possible and land on the other side.

I'm glad you made it through the *Unavoidables*. Now that you have some tips and tools for navigating them and a more realistic understanding of what they entail, it's time to move beyond the point of no return. So, buckle up because we are about to set the best conditions for innovation to occur.

This chapter does not discuss half-measures, make things look easy, or celebrate mediocrity. It's here to show you with extreme honesty an unfiltered version of what we entrepreneurs need to sacrifice and do in order to pursue our passions. This might feel polarizing for you—and it is! But in the next few minutes, I genuinely want you to know if this is your call or if you would rather just watch how things turn out.

Don't worry if this is not for you; maybe you are still here because of curiosity. I believe that it's also totally honorable to add value to the world in your way. Innovations can be big or small, global or regional. As long as you enhance others' lives, people will support you—and so will I. We must recognize that the world will progress with or without us; we're not special for wanting to improve lives—this should be the norm.

If you feel the call, as if destiny has laid the first stone on your path and an urge burns deep inside you, then the next steps are for you. This book isn't meant to be passively consumed—it's only as valuable as the actions you take afterward. If you finish this book without taking action or making any changes in your life, I have failed you, but if it taught you something, sparks new ideas, or motivates you, it has been worth it.

You must carefully choose what you are signing up for, trading your comfort, stability, certainty, time, energy, and resources for an unguaranteed chance to add value through your project. The unavoidable uncertainty doses will give you fear, stress, and anxiety; getting stuck will consume your resources and patience; and failure will test if you are truly unbreakable. You will need all the courage, perseverance, and love for your project to fully commit to it.

If you try to venture without actually knowing what problem you want to solve, you might encounter another unexpected challenge. For me, it took me by surprise, but for the first years of my journey, I suffered from isolation. My purposes were too broad, and the ways of getting there were quite undefined. Isolation is not that I didn't have friends or see any other people; it meant that I had almost no one who could understand my particular path—including other entrepreneur friends with different incentives and goals. It's natural to feel like this when you intend to go where no one else has gone, but as you define the problem you want to solve, you will eventually find other innovators on the same journey. Discussing all the similarities, struggles, and craziest moments will keep you sane, and you will stop feeling alone.

Before you decide to commit, you will want to be clear about your incentives, goals, and the one problem you want to solve. The closer the problem is to you, the more likely it will genuinely motivate you to solve it. Seneca, the Roman Stoic philosopher known for his timeless wisdom, once said: “If a man knows not to which port he sails, no wind is favorable.” So, effort without a clear problem and destination is like rowing a boat in different directions every couple of hours; you can easily waste your energy and still stay lost. Before committing, you should be dead serious about where you want to go and what you want to fix in the world!!

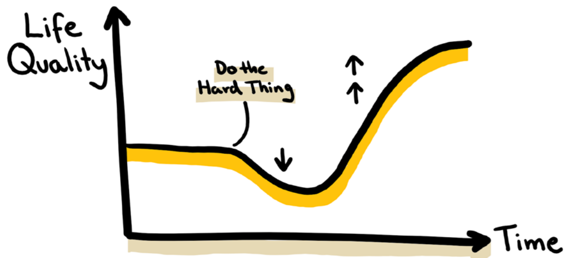
When I started my first venture, *WeSpark*, I didn’t know what precisely I wanted to do. I was certain it would be an innovation agency focused on designing, building, and workshopping rather than just talking and consulting about “innovation.” However, over the first months, I quickly realized that selling “innovation workshops” was not what I wanted to do. There was a lack of sustenance and real incentives. After a while, I figured that the real purpose was to learn by co-building the most exciting products, and then we should educate and expose the adoption of an innovative mindset to the ones who need it most. This led to the decision that *WeSpark* needed to include charitable causes every quarter. It became easy to decide what to do in every situation because once the purpose was clear, we knew which decisions added value to it and which didn’t. Therefore, take your time to discover what you truly live for.

Once you know which problem requires your innovative mindset and actions, you know it is time to commit. If you pay attention to others’ conversations, you will hear that most people tend to express their intentions, but their incentives are not solid, so they rarely take action and do anything. One of my favorite educators, Chris Do, is known for his famous saying, “Whatever I say I want, I must do, else I’m not allowed to say that I want it.” Committing is exactly that; instead of taking your precious time to tell everyone around what you plan to do, you can start doing that thing you want with full conviction. Actions are more valuable than words: usually, words tell you what the other person wants you to believe their intentions are, and actions show their actual intentions.

Surround yourself with the right people who understand and support your commitment; they recognize that your actions matter and will encourage you to continue. The people you want to disassociate from are the ones who will see your endeavor with superficial eyes; they will try to distract you from achieving your goals, and they will criticize your work without adding any valuable feedback. At the start of your journey, it will be challenging to differentiate those who support you from those who distract you. So remember, you are the one with the commitment, not them. With time, your journey will help you curate the people closest to you, leaving you with the friendships you truly deserve.

As you progress, not only will the right people reveal themselves, but so will the temptations that can mislead your path, testing your commitment and incentives. At the beginning, you might visualize the outcome and the happy ending, accompanied by a softened version of the pain and sacrifices you'll endure. You may doubt yourself at times, but if you find yourself moving forward with your project despite all warnings, that's true conviction. On the one hand, conviction is needed; it will let you act with momentum and feel sure about every decision, but remember to carefully choose your incentives because weak ones can allow your conviction to blind you and make a fool of yourself. Don't let feelings of grandeur, big valuation numbers, and status symbols win over your mind; these temptations can easily misalign you from your purpose. As Epicurus, the ancient Greek philosopher known for his teachings on happiness and contentment, wisely stated, "Do not spoil what you have by desiring what you have not; remember that what you now have was once among the things you only hoped for." Don't let weak incentives deceive you.

If your true intention is to commit, you will notice that everything seems to get harder as you progress—because it is! In his popular lecture, *How to Live an Asymmetric Life*, Graham Weaver argues that when tackling hard things, your life may initially deteriorate: you'll face complex topics, struggle in your new job, and your salary may decrease. He explains that the first move will always be the hardest and may even cause fear. However, as you learn and progress, the curve of life flattens, and with sustained effort, things will improve, often exceeding the quality of life you had before undertaking “the hard thing.”



Remember this natural progression: things often get worse before they get better. Whenever your situation becomes difficult, don’t stop hustling; you now know that progress requires full commitment and hard work until you see improvements. This is the path we must commit to if we are serious about innovation.

While it’s often said that to become an entrepreneur, you sacrifice everything, a more accurate statement would be: “As an entrepreneur, you sacrifice everything irrelevant to you.” In that sense, commitment is simply the act of eliminating alternatives. An easy way to understand this is through a concept I was introduced to in one of the knowledge-sharing groups I told you in Chapter 4: “Absence is greater than Presence.” For example, if your goal is to lose weight, you might think that the presence of sports will help you most; after all, it can be strenuous hard work—a tangible effort. Still, when you compare it to the absence of food, you will quickly notice that eating 20% less will most likely achieve 80% of the desired results, and doing lots of sports might consume 80% of the energy and achieve only 20% of the results. This concept is present everywhere; in business modeling, you say “simple is better,” in marketing, you say “less is more,” and others might just know it as the *Pareto* principle.

To achieve your innovation, you have to narrow down the purpose of your ideas and focus your energy on solving your chosen problem. This often leads to successful niche business ideas that are highly profitable due to a lack of competition. When you differentiate from everyone else, you are clearly on the path of innovation.

For instance, our experience at *WeSpark* perfectly illustrates how focusing on a niche can lead to remarkable success. At one point, we got so experienced at designing and executing workshops that we started winning the most demanding customers with the most challenging scenarios.

On one particular occasion, we accepted a contract to run a workshop where our customer organized five C-level executives from their network to meet with five startup founders. All the startups had different products in different stages, and all the top executives were from various companies within the same industry. The goal was to ensure that at least one of the five pairs would close a deal and start working together after a single workshop day.

For our paying client, this was a sensible matter; it was not only costly to organize that everyone would join from different cities, but they knew they had a single shot to nail the workshop. My team and I took the proper time to diagnose the problem and offered our client that we would take the challenge, design, and execute the one-day workshop for $20,000. We guaranteed that at least one of the five pairs would enter business or secure an investment deal. I knew that guaranteeing such an outcome was risky. However, we minimized those risks by thoroughly preparing and leveraging our expertise and scarce combination of skills.

The commitment was real; we put our time and resources at stake and, more importantly, our reputation. We prepared two full days for the workshop, learning every public detail about every participant we could gather. I wanted to know everything to be prepared for every scenario.

Thanks to specializing in designing unique innovation methodologies, this task was not only possible but also exciting. We then designed a multi-modular structure that allowed each pair to pursue their goals seamlessly and in parallel. I'm sure this workshop design would be terrible at everything else, but it was certainly the best way to solve this problem. In the end, the workshop concluded successfully, with three out of the five pairs closing deals on the spot.

This experience taught me that by deeply understanding the client's needs and committing fully to preparing intensively and delivering exceptional value, we could achieve outcomes that seemed improbable. It reinforced the importance of specializing in a niche. Ultimately, this success satisfied our client and led to increased trust and more high-profile projects.

When it comes to innovation, commitment isn't just about starting a project—it's about committing to every single detail and every step of the way. This is exemplified by my friend Forrest Heath, an entrepreneur who took the bold step of mastering the entire telecom ecosystem. His company, *Somos Internet*, controls everything from negotiating submarine cable contracts to building their own network infrastructure, including routers that deliver Wi-Fi directly to the customer. By committing to understanding and controlling every part of the technology stack and the value chain end-to-end, Forrest has built the fastest, most cost-effective internet service in the world. It's 1000 times cheaper per megabit than *Starlink*, with speeds 100 times faster. It's a clear example of what's possible when you put in the effort and go all in. This is a true commitment to not just looking for answers but looking for the right questions—this is a full commitment to knowledge.

The niche path can be lonelier; you will be the one expanding the market alone, testing assumptions, spending the most on research and development, and taking the most risks. Keeping committed under this first-mover pressure is key to enduring uncertain moments, getting unstuck, or failing forward. That's why you learned that truly wanting to solve a problem is essential and why keeping your "critical thinking" abilities sharp, trained, and ready matters. If you overcome these obstacles, your commitment will pay off quickly.

Speaking of rapid developments, remember that we learned in Chapter 2 that technological acceleration is exponential. Thanks to communications technology, the rate at which you can grow your projects can go faster than ever—and you don't want to be overwhelmed. In the beginning, the pace of growth is slow, but with your sustained effort and smart decisions, it will start to get moderately faster and faster. At some point, you will go through the breakthrough, and the next phase of growth and experimentation will begin.

In retrospect, things can look fast, but your mindset needs to be aligned with the fact that anything with the potential to truly and positively change lives will take a long time to build. This doesn't mean you shouldn't iterate quickly on your ideas until you find one that solves the problem, but it does mean you should dedicate sufficient time to discover what works, recognizing that anything worth pursuing will require significant effort.

As an innovator, you are in it for the long term—commitment is key! One of the most powerful statements you can learn today comes from serial entrepreneur and educator Alex Hormozi, author of *$100M Offers* and *$100M Leads*. He argues that "Volume negates Luck," explaining that if you prepare more for the activities that matter and focus on doing something that has been working for you hundreds or thousands of times—and then do it for several years—as a result, you will become the best at doing it.

Alex doesn't believe in luck if there's a way to overcome it through repeated, effort-demanding activities. In fact, he argues that to truly excel, you need to exert orders of magnitude more effort than you initially think. Instead of merely doubling or tripling your efforts, he suggests thinking in terms of 10, 100, or even dedicating 1,000 times more effort to achieving your goals—this is best accomplished with an efficient and motivated team.

If we consider the goalkeeper's example in Chapter 1 as promising innovators, we need to rethink statements we believe to be true. Perhaps the best goalkeeper is just the one who puts substantially more training than everyone else, and with his skills and presence, the goalkeeper might have luck on his side. For example, if a striker misses a shot out of nervousness against the world's best goalkeeper, is it luck or skill?

My favorite statement from Hormozi, which needs no further explanation and is potentially the most profound, inspiring, simple, raw, yet impactful, is: "Extraordinary accomplishments come from doing ordinary things for extraordinary periods of time."

When you are in the thrill of it, experiencing exponential innovation and growth, you need to remember to keep your emotions stable. Don't panic when things go exceptionally well or terribly; it's just part of the process. When extreme emotions threaten to dominate your actions, take a few moments to breathe and calm down before making your next strategic decision. That's one of the hardest lessons I had to endure: making fast, risky decisions reacting to a crazy situation.

You might feel overwhelmed the first time but try to remain relaxed by mentally preparing for various outcomes. Epicurus, whom we introduced earlier, argued, "Nothing is enough for the man to whom enough is too little." From an innovation and entrepreneurship perspective, you are not trying just to reach a goal and be done with it. Especially if you commit to reaching a specific goal while expecting it will make you happy, it will not. Whatever number you have in your head, you will always want it higher. The only way to be satisfied is if achieving your purpose little by little every day makes you feel grateful. Whether it’s concepts like having a specific amount of money or achieving “freedom,” it’s best to enjoy the journey, not the goal. Accumulating more sound money month to month, exercising more freedom choices daily, or helping one more person each day are more sustainable ways to appreciate your progress than merely waiting to reach goals.

You are ready to commit if you have the innovator’s mindset, skills, and knowledge and have chosen your problem to solve. Before continuing, please read this pledge out loud:

I desire what few are willing to; I desire to work hard and embrace sacrifices today for the chance to build a better future tomorrow.

8. EUDAIMONIA

Life has a way of humbling us. Since taking an oath to become an entrepreneur committed to positively impacting the world, I've encountered more chaos and instability than ever before. In my time on this earth, I've been part of beautiful stories and witnessed nightmares alike. It's this stark contrast—the good, the bad, and the ugly—that has shaped who I am today.

In ancient Greek philosophy, Eudaimonia is a concept with different emphasis when viewed from the multiple philosophies that reference it. Here, we will look at Eudaimonia from the perspective of Stoicism and focus on its practicability in pursuing innovation and entrepreneurship. Before getting into Eudaimonia's concept, I must tell you about the last time I identified other individuals with stoic, solid traits.

Recently, I traveled to Ukraine to visit friends. It was a profound experience, marking my second visit since the Russian invasion began. While we were fortunate not to face immediate danger during this trip, a series of experiences left a lasting impression on me. Every night, multiple air raid sirens shattered the silence. The sound, chilling and inescapable, warns of imminent danger. Each time the sirens rang, I had to come to terms with the possibility of death in the next few minutes—sometimes dozens of times a day. In those moments, I realized how little most things truly matter. What counts is the love we share with family, friends, and those around us.

The first alarm happened in the first hour after arriving in *Chernihiv* as we walked outside to the post office. To my surprise, an old lady walking just by my side didn't even seem to react to the loud siren's noise. When I looked at other people around us, it was the same behavior; life continued as usual.

One day, I visited a hospital for a routine checkup on my lungs, which had been affected by allergies in recent years. The building was an old Soviet-era structure, as many other hospitals had been destroyed in the conflict.

While the doctor listed treatments and medications in Ukrainian, I struggled to keep up, feeling my anxiety grow as her notes filled the page. Then, the sirens blared again—the doctor didn't react—and she flipped the page and continued writing. This time, a nurse burst into the room, visibly distressed, and we were instructed to head to the shelter. Descending the stairs, we joined others in the cramped space. Yet, within minutes, my friend and I decided to return to the surface and drive back home.

What struck me most was how the locals carried on despite the constant threat. Fear is an emotion almost impossible to disguise—it's visible in the eyes. Yet doctors and nurses remained focused on their work. Parents and patients waited calmly. A man near the entrance continued eating his ice cream as if nothing had happened.

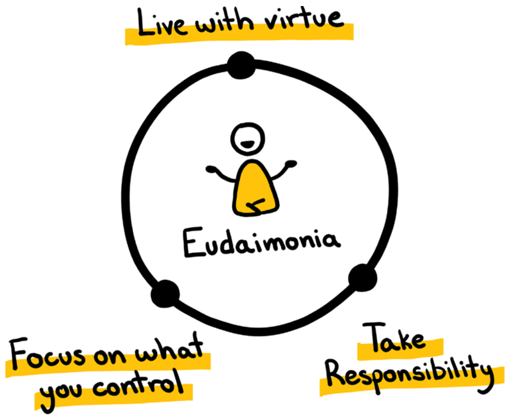
So I kept reflecting on it and eventually concluded that many locals live by some Stoicism principles and unknowingly practice Eudaimonia to some degree. They live with courage and help others in need, taking responsibility each time and not letting anything out of their control manipulate their feelings. In war, you see the worst of humanity, but you also see the best. In war, you witness both the worst and the best of humanity. Extreme stress and fear reveal a person's true identity and intentions. Ukrainians need our support. If you can spare a dollar, please consider donating to their charities.

Every contribution makes a difference. You can find a couple of links in the *Resources and Links* section at the end of the book.

Eudaimonia comes from two Greek terms: *Eu-* means *good*, and *daimon* means *spirit*. Together, it signifies *good spirit*, but a more practical way to interpret it is: "to be good with your inner spirit."

For Stoics, Eudaimonia is achieved by living in accordance with nature and reason, but understanding hundreds of abstract philosophical concepts is complicated; therefore, we resort to one of the best and simplest visualizations and stoic overviews: In *The Little Book of Stoicism*, Jonas Salzgeber argues that in the ultimate goal of reaching Eudaimonia, you can divide the stoics practices into three different categories:

- Live with virtue.
- Focus on what you control.
- Take responsibility.



LIVE WITH VIRTUE

This powerful concept encourages you to strive to be the best version of yourself every day. Every decision you make should come from a place of good intentions. To live this way, you aim to be the best relative, friend, neighbor, and citizen you can imagine. But because we are human, mistakes are inevitable, and there will always be room to grow and improve.

Whenever I faced a tough decision, my mother would tell me to listen to my heart for the right choice. More often than not, the right choice was also the harder one. But regardless of the challenge, if you remain aware and present, you give yourself the opportunity to consciously choose the best path. Ideally, that choice will align with virtue and uphold the highest moral standards.

Stoic philosophy offers guidance here, dividing virtue into four essential characteristics: wisdom, courage, justice, and moderation.

To live virtuously, you must cultivate wisdom to guide your emotions and actions through life's challenges. Courage will help you face and endure life's most daunting moments. A strong sense of justice will enable you to discern right from wrong. Finally, moderation and self-discipline will allow you to resist temptations and weak incentives.

When you embark on any project, your path to long-term success depends on being the best version of yourself. By focusing on uplifting others and improving the world through your innovations, you attract better people into your life and open the door to more meaningful opportunities.

Choosing virtue is choosing mental clarity and calmness. When you do the right thing, good things are more likely to follow. But the opposite is also true: if you let temptations dictate your decisions, you'll eventually face the consequences.

One of the most compelling pieces of wisdom I ever heard was shared with me by Adam Nili, a successful entrepreneur, philanthropist, and friend:

"In today's world, we're surrounded by endless choices. Every day brings new opportunities, temptations, and quick shortcuts that promise success. But the truth is, you can have anything you want in life—you just can't have everything. To achieve excellent results, you need focus. And one of the most powerful tools for focus is the ability to say *no*.

Saying *no* isn't just about declining an offer or passing on a project—it's about prioritizing. It's about choosing where to direct your time, energy, and attention. By saying *no* to distractions, you create the space to excel in the areas that matter most to you.

No is more powerful than saying *yes*. *Yes* is easy—it's the default that opens doors to everything. But *no* is intentional—it sharpens your focus, defines your priorities, and aligns your actions with your goals. When you say *no*, you set boundaries that allow you to invest deeply in what truly matters.

The most extraordinary achievements don't come from doing many things halfway; they come from dedicating yourself to a few things wholeheartedly. Those who understand this principle say *no* to spreading themselves too thin. Instead, they focus on becoming exceptional in one or two areas, choosing depth over breadth.

In the end, your ability to say *no* determines your path. It becomes a filter that separates what's essential from what's merely possible, allowing you to build a life of meaning, purpose, and impact. By focusing on the few things that matter most, you open the door to extraordinary results—and to a future that's truly yours".

So, we learned from Adam that it's not only the decisions we make that define who we are but the decisions that we decide not to make that truly define us. Fighting the biggest temptations is what separates the weak from the strong.

As an entrepreneur, you will be more exposed to temptations and non-virtuous opportunities. When I faced uncertainty, as described in Chapter 6, I was offered a six-digit commission just by connecting one of my contacts with a potential supplier. Upon checking the offer, I noticed that it was a delivery of overpriced, dubious-quality COVID masks. Just reading it felt wrong, and I remember calling my father to make sure I wasn't insane in denying to help straight away. My father listened to me and told me: “Son, I’ve made many mistakes, but when I go to bed, I sleep well.” And though I was going through my first financial crisis then, the answer was clear—I said no.

Years later, I saw a report about some investigations in the news where the local authorities were exposing several shady deals that happened during the pandemic, and it became clearer than ever that my decision saved me from life-damaging consequences in the future. When you design and build products, services, or platforms that align with the values of living in virtue, your organization will be blessed with a pristine reputation and the best team and customers you can wish for.

FOCUS ON WHAT YOU CONTROL

Living with virtue sounds beautiful, but if it were that easy, our lives would have no conflicts or stress. Every day, we deal with a whirlwind of emotions, letting them surface and take over as reactions to the external world.

Everyone we interact with and every situation we encounter influences how we feel. And in the end, we’re the only ones who can decide just how much power those influences have over us. Yet, because we are emotional beings and not machines, we often let raw emotions take the wheel, leading us in directions we may not want to go.

One of the most popular ideas in stoicism is the belief that we can consciously decide how to respond to external factors rather than allowing our emotions to take control.

A familiar example is when we have a heated discussion with someone we deeply care about. In that fiery moment, we sometimes say things we shouldn't, things we don't truly mean, and things we instantly regret. Words have the power to shatter relationships or even bring down companies. As Solomon Gabirol, the medieval philosopher and poet, once said: "As long as a word remains unspoken, you are its master; once you utter it, you are its slave."

Like the brave Ukrainians at the beginning of this chapter, we need to be more calm and aware of what we can and can't control. If we let the things we can't control dictate our lives, we've already given up our power. The past is set in stone; it can't be changed, so worrying about it is wasted energy. The future isn't here yet, so we act on it only when it arrives. What matters most is the here and now.

At some point in your innovation journey, external factors—such as a recession, war, pandemic, natural disasters, or technological disruption—will inevitably impact your project. When that moment comes, remember this: you can't go back in time to prevent it, but you can prepare for the challenges that are likely to come. If you've studied the Megatrends from Chapter 4, you'll already have a sense of what might disrupt your plans.

Other times, there is no way of knowing or preparing, and the only approach that you can take is to breathe slowly for a few minutes, practice *peripatetic learning* as we learned in Chapter 6.2, and surrender to the idea that you can't influence most things out. Once you internalize this, you'll free yourself to channel all your energy into solving the problems that are within your reach.

TAKE RESPONSIBILITY

When you live virtuously and learn to keep your emotions in check by focusing only on what you can control, the next step is deciding how to act. Awareness of the moment gives you an advantage most people don't have. The final piece of the puzzle is choosing actions that add the greatest value.

With the wisdom you've gained, you are equipped to face challenges in your next venture and beyond. If you cultivate an innovator's mindset, expand your knowledge, and sharpen your skills, you have no excuse not to take action. Our world is full of problems that need our attention, and if we, the innovators, don't rise to the occasion, no one else will.

Knowledge itself is power, and with power comes responsibility. The next time you recognize a moment of truth, you will have everything you need to be an exemplary innovator and take responsibility.

SATOSHI

A modern example of Eudaimonia in action is the unknown creator of Bitcoin, who is undoubtedly one of the greatest innovators of our time. Even though we only know this person (or persons) by the pseudonym *Satoshi Nakamoto*, it's easy to argue that Satoshi follows the concepts of Eudaimonia.

Satoshi lived with virtue: Since the publication of the Bitcoin Whitepaper, the technical documentation that explains its mechanics, the intention behind Bitcoin was to address ethical concerns in finance. Satoshi promoted fairness, published his work to create a better version of money, and made it available to the connected world.

Nakamoto's wisdom can be observed in BTC's sound game theory: the entire blockchain is decentralized and stored transparently. At the same time, the reward system incentivizes all actors to behave properly and demotivates any bad actors.

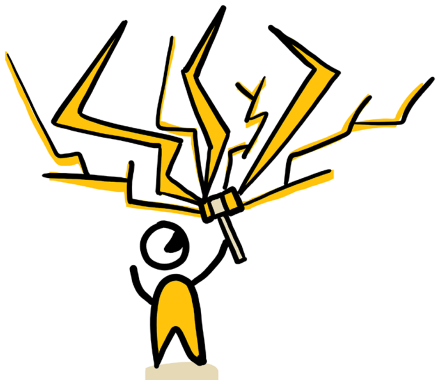
Starting a project that challenges the mechanism of corruption requires immense courage, and if Satoshi's identity were revealed, his, her, or their life would be instantly in danger. Designing, publishing, and leading the development of Bitcoin at the very beginning are huge acts of bravery. On the other hand, promoting fairness and equality by designing a system to democratize access to financial systems requires a strong sense of justice.

The fact that Satoshi remained anonymous, avoided fame, and despite holding a significant amount of Bitcoin, Nakamoto resisted realizing any personal gains proves that Satoshi practices extreme moderation and self-discipline to live in virtue.

Fixing the flaws of the international monetary system is a challenge far beyond the control of any single individual. But Satoshi understood where to focus and what could be controlled. Rather than fighting against or attempting to reform the existing system, Nakamoto channeled all effort and skill into creating a better alternative.

After Bitcoin started growing and more developers joined worldwide, Satoshi stepped back from the Bitcoin project, demonstrating acceptance that its future is beyond individual control. This entire initiative and undertaking is enough evidence to argue that Satoshi took responsibility.

Just like innovation's impact, goodwill compounds, too. If we could all be a bit more like Satoshi Nakamoto and follow the principles of Eudaimonia, the world would be a better place.



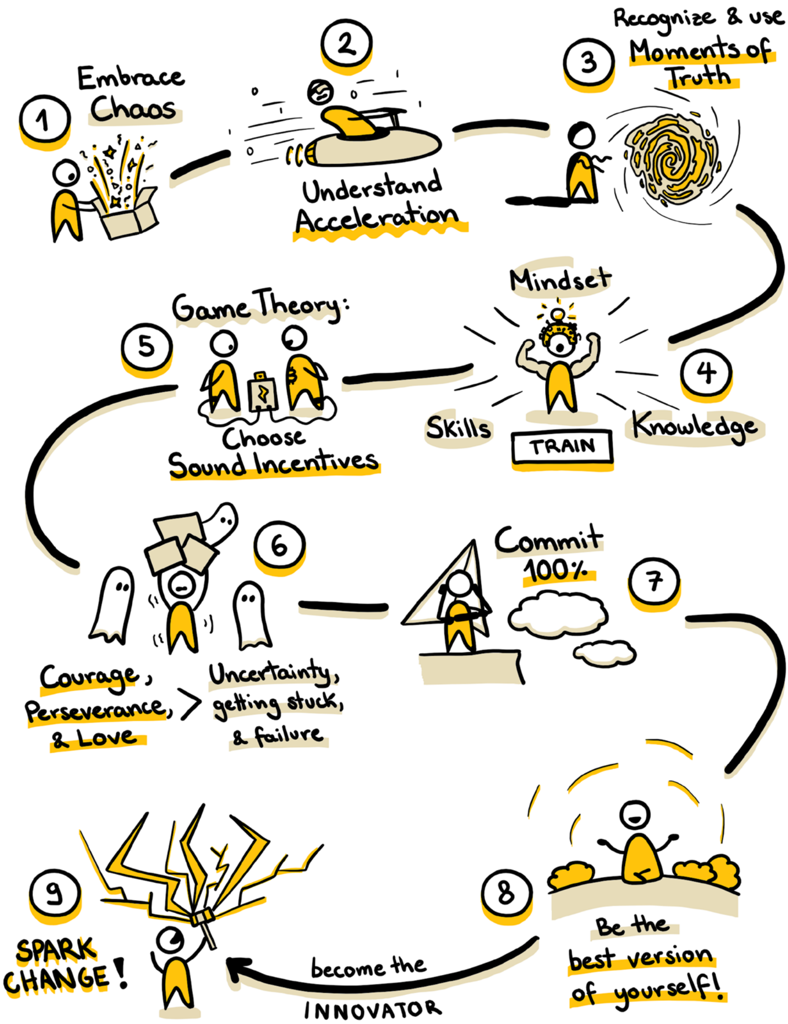
9. Spark

Every five seconds, somewhere in the world, someone takes the first step toward realizing their dreams. A single spark ignites and sets everything in motion. Dreams turn into words, words turn into actions, and actions turn into innovation. Tens of thousands more innovators, entrepreneurs, and creators take the leap of faith each day, joining us on the mission to share our ideas with the world.

We are an unstoppable force. We are untamable. We are the ones who spark change.

We are the ones who don't ignore the problems of the world, and against all odds, we hold together the fragile state of *Unstable Innovation*.

What did we learn so far? Here's everything in a nutshell:



1. You must embrace chaos and know that innovation and coming up with ideas can work in mysterious ways.
2. Understand that technological advancement compounds, accelerating its pace and creating new opportunities.
3. The world is unfair, but knowing that, you need to act accordingly: When the moments of truth present themselves, you should be ready to recognize and utilize them; they are hidden opportunities in disguise.
4. You want to train your mindset, knowledge, and skills to improve your chances of activating the fragile and unstable innovative state of mind.
5. The entire world of business and innovation works based on Game Theory, which will naturally drag you towards entrepreneurship. Choosing and building on sound incentives will improve your chances of success.
6. Uncertainty, getting stuck, and failure are unavoidable obstacles in the path of innovation, but you can fight them with courage, perseverance, and love for solving a problem.
7. The innovator’s way is to commit fully and take action repeatedly; you will do this until you become the best in what you do.
8. You need to live with the aspiration of being the best version of yourself every single day.
9. Ultimately, you will combine all the learnings and spark positive change in the world!

We are incredible beings! Even though our bodies and brains have not had too much time to evolve and change since we were still poking things with a stick, we are still able to build amazing projects that allow us to travel comfortably around the world, communicate with every other human being in seconds, and even travel into space.

But because we are basically still primates with clothes and technology, sometimes the accelerated change and the access to global news can give us the feeling that our Earth is falling apart. But does this mean our world is broken? The answer is no. We live in a world filled with injustice, inequality, and challenges, and as we strive to adapt to technology, we find ourselves navigating a difficult period. Yet, in our pursuit of progress, we have developed systems that enable us to understand, document, store, and access the vast collective wisdom of humanity. This incredible advancement allows future generations to learn from the past and benefit from the comfort and improved quality of life that previous discoveries and innovations offer.

Every year, we become better and more efficient at harnessing, storing, and utilizing the energy from the universe. Decade to decade, we are getting closer to becoming a *Type I* civilization on the *Kardashev scale* that measures and classifies the progress of civilizations based on how they handle energy.

Three hundred eighty-five thousand babies are born daily, many of whom will become scientists, artists, philosophers, engineers, and have other specializations. They will go through more efficient methods of learning, critical thinking, and problem-solving, most likely powered by AI. We should believe that each of them could, like you and me, ignite that spark deep within them and change the course of history.

So, what does the future look like? I don't know, but whether or not the world is broken or progressing is just a mere change in your perception. If you decide today that the world will be a better place and contribute to realizing that projection, you will make it a little bit better each day. If we work together, we can make each day on Earth the best it ever was.

And because technology and goodwill compound on each other, each day that passes is the most important day in our history, not in terms of published innovations and other announcements, but in terms of new ideas, methods, and discoveries that are created without us being aware yet.

Altogether, what we are living through is the most exciting era of human civilization so far, and in the next decades and hundreds of years, humanity is set to go through the next exponential phase of hyper-scalability and innovation.

Now, innovation is peculiar: it will require you to acknowledge when you are wrong about something. Growing up in El Salvador, there was non-stop violence in the media; it was the most dangerous country in the world, and as soon as I could, I left it to pursue a new life in Europe. However, as the years went by, I started to get involved in charitable activities for my country and started supporting by sharing what I had been learning on the old continent.

Even though nothing changed at first, in the last half a decade, El Salvador has experienced a breakthrough in culture and change. Even though a couple of decades ago it was one of the most dangerous places on Earth, today, my country is not only one of the safest in all the Americas, but it is also going through a phase of technological and cultural renaissance. Most will not see it at first, but now it's crystal clear: While problems still exist, I noticed first-hand brilliant individuals and builders moving to El Salvador. Today, the country has a promising future and will probably become a beacon of hope and innovation in the entire region. So, I understood that for half of my life, I've been entirely wrong about how fast or not things could improve.

The most powerful thing your mind can do is disassociate from the truths you've adopted and believed, and rewire itself to accept a new, alternative truth that is closer to reality, based on new information.

In simple words, the combined ability to unthink and rethink thoughts in different ways will be the one ability that will change your mind on everything. After you acquire this ability, you cannot do anything else but answer the call of innovation. Doing this can be quite scary, as you leave a comfortable truth for the discomfort of having to relearn everything. However, just learning and acknowledging it is not enough; you have to rediscover this new perspective by verifying yourself. Therefore, I decided to spend more time in El Salvador each year, bring my mindset, knowledge, and skills, and become part of the change. Still, to be part of the change, I will keep within the field where I know I excel—that's innovation and education—what I know how to do best. I'll be one person, but I'll make a dent.

One person with a strong idea. This is all it takes to ignite the spark; assuming you enjoy the topics in this book, this person could be you. With the right incentives in mind, you might see what most don't see and be right about something where everyone else in the world is wrong. In order to be competitive, build your idea, and prove your point, you will have to focus your energy on that one problem you can solve, regardless of whether others believe in you. You will specialize in that topic, you will believe in yourself—and you will build.

It will be hard. Perhaps it will be the hardest thing you ever do, but you will persevere. You will persevere because you love what you do—you sweat and bleed for it—and just when you think it can’t be worse, life will humble you again. But you are courageous; you are a fighter for a better future, and if you stick to your vision long enough, one day, you will see it realized.

Innovation is a fragile state of mind that most people will never experience and, therefore, will never understand. But be careful! This doesn’t entitle you or me to go around, even with the sightless feeling of superiority. We are not. The same flesh and blood make us; the only difference is that we have an added responsibility just because we are aware of it.

Some of the greatest ideas were created during the hardest of times, and I expect that due to the acceleration of change, we will probably have a couple more turbulent and uncertain decades. The whole purpose of this book is to share the little knowledge and wisdom I have accumulated through making lots of mistakes, hoping that it will help you and others navigate through the coming years of transition.

If you feel like you are burning from the inside out and ready to change the world, please learn and take this book's deeper philosophical meaning. The wisest opinions in this book were documented by more thoughtful people in the past who couldn’t even imagine our world today. Even though these learnings have been shared for thousands of years, their wisdom still holds immense value. Don't learn to recite them—it's not about memorizing—but please practice and embody what you have learned, and you will never feel lost.

Your life is unique, and as long as we know, it's the only one you will ever get. So use it to change what you need to, and consider that everything I have mentioned so far is just a simple collection of assumptions. What is true today might be wrong tomorrow, as change is the only constant. So, you are the only judge of your thoughts and actions and the one who has to take responsibility.

So, it's time to go out there and visualize your ideas by building them. Put all your passion into them and nurture them with your time and dedication, and as you narrow them down to the one thing where you excel, the reward and fulfillment will be to see your idea become a reality. Creativity is not the secret that makes your idea exceptional. What makes it exceptional is your honest work and the long, humbling, and hard journey that will improve your idea and build a better tomorrow.

Before you go on your journey, take my Mantra with you and make it yours:

"Be the ordinary, build the extraordinary."

WHAT'S NEXT?

Before anything, thank you very much for reading this book. I hope you are feeling “pumped” and craving to build the next thing.

This is my first book, so to be able to write a better one, I would love to know if you liked it. What was your favorite part? And where is room for potential? I’ll make sure to read and reply to your comments!

You can learn more about the projects I’ve built and mentioned, leave feedback, get in contact with me, or watch my TEDxTalk “Are Schools Prepared for the Future?” at www.unstableinnovation.com

So, what’s next? You should check the *Resources and Links* section and explore some of the technologies and topics mentioned in the book. Here, you will find everything you need to kickstart your journey.

Who will you recommend to read this book? If you enjoyed this book, think about one person in your life who could truly benefit from it. Be resourceful and gift it to this person while you go out there and start putting all new learnings into practice :)

RESOURCES AND LINKS

Use the following resources and links to expand your wisdom and knowledge, and get in touch with me if you have any open questions about the concepts or methods mentioned here.

Connect and talk with Nelson on LinkedIn:

Mega Concentration Playlist on Spotify:

Watch Nelson's TEDxTalk: Are Schools prepared for the future?

Learn more about the Innovation Agency WeSpark

Discover more about the author and watch the video biography:

Here's how to create a NOSTR profile and auto-connect with me and other innovators mentioned in this book:

start.njump.me

If you can’t scan it, you can still create a profile and add me manually with the QR or NPUB address on the right.

Watch the video: What is Bitcoin and why does it matter?

Alternatively, you can start using *NOSTR*, by downloading or using clients such as Damus or Primal.

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Feel free to suggest additional resources, ask questions, or share your thoughts through the book's official website.

And don't forget to visit UNSTABLE INNOVATION's website https://www.unstableinnovation.com/ to join our community of innovators. Here, you will find more resources and tips to ensure you are as prepared as possible when your moment of truth summons you.

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Thank you, reader, for spending your valuable time here. If you have made it this far, I want to know who you are. Please visit unstableinnovation.com and get in touch with me!

Finally, thank you, Grandma Haydee, for making me promise to write this book—it tells of my life, kings, courage, perseverance, and love. One day, I'll join you and tell you all about it.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Nelson Inno is a Salvadoran innovation enthusiast dedicated to creating and developing new products, services, and digital experiences across various industries. He has established multiple ventures, each aimed at pushing the boundaries of what's possible.

With a background that includes roles at leading global companies, Nelson has developed a deep expertise in solving complex problems through creative methods. His work extends beyond traditional business, having collaborated on high-impact projects at the European Union level and contributed to advancing innovation management practices.

Nelson is laser-focused on developing and using technology to serve humanity and is interested in the spatial internet, decentralized engagement, the future of education, and Bitcoin.

Inno is committed to guiding future generations through sharing his knowledge and creating educational courses and platforms that drive meaningful, positive change. He lives by and teaches his favorite Mantra:

"BE THE ORDINARY. BUILD THE EXTRAORDINARY"

UNSTABLE INNOVATION

Are you frustrated by the bureaucracy that slows down innovation? Do traditional playbooks and step-by-step frameworks leave you uninspired and stuck?

In **Unstable Innovation: The Fragile State Most Will Never Understand**, discover how embracing chaos and uncertainty can unleash your inner genius. This book dives headfirst into the unpredictable, accelerated world where real breakthroughs happen, guiding you to utilize instability in your favor and ignite the first spark.

Inside, you'll learn how to:

- ✔ Embrace fragility and uncertainty to spark true innovation.
- ✔ Identify and seize the crucial moments that make a difference.
- ✔ Break free from outdated corporate frameworks that hinder progress.
- ✔ Turn unpredictability into actionable steps toward success.
- ✔ Sharpen your mindset, knowledge, and skills to become the best version of yourself and turn problems into opportunities!

Whether you're a rebel entrepreneur or someone truly craving to break free from traditional business limitations, **Unstable Innovation** offers a direct, unfiltered approach to thriving in the fragile moments where extraordinary ideas are born.

Transform your perspective, unleash your maximum potential, and embark on the extraordinary path to innovation. Your journey starts here!

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